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### Determining a resolution state of an anchor constant associated with an application programming interface (API) point

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#### Abstract

A parametric constant resolves to different values in different contexts, but a single value within a particular context. An anchor constant is a parametric constant that allows for a degree of parametricity for an API point. The context for the anchor constant is provided by a caller to the API point. The anchor constant resolves to an anchor value that records specialization decisions for the API point within the provided context. Specialization decisions may include type restrictions, memory layout, and/or memory size. The anchor value together with an unspecialized type of the API point result in a specialized type of the API point. A class object representing the specialized type is created. The class object may be accessible to the caller, but the full value of the anchor value is not accessible to the caller. The API point is executed based on the specialization decisions embodied in the anchor value.

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## **Background/Summary**

### **RELATED APPLICATIONS; INCORPORATION BY REFERENCE**

(1) This application hereby incorporates by reference the following applications: Application No. 63/163,697, filed on Mar. 19, 2021, titled “Dynamically Imposed Field and Method Type Restrictions For Managed Execution Environments”; Application No. 63/163,701, filed on Mar. 19, 2021, titled “Optional Specialization of Generic Types and Methods”; Application No. 63/163,723, filed on Mar. 19, 2021, titled “Encapsulated Specialization of Dynamically-Linked API Points”; Application No. 63/163,726, filed on Mar. 19, 2021, titled “Pointwise and Replicative Type Specializations”; application Ser. No. 17/571,323, filed on Jan. 7, 2022 titled “Dynamically-Imposed Field and Method Type Restrictions for Managed Execution Environments”; application Ser. No. 17/571,328, filed on Jan. 7, 2022 titled “Implementing Optional Specialization When Executing Code”; application Ser. No. 17/571,329, filed on Jan. 7, 2022 titled “Implementing Optional Specialization When Compiling Code”; application Ser. No. 17/571,335, filed on Jan. 7, 2022 titled “Determining different resolution states for a parametric constant in different contexts”; application Ser. No. 17/571,343, filed on Jan. 7, 2022 titled “Executing a parametric method within a specialized context”; application Ser. No. 17/571,349, filed on Jan. 7, 2022 titled “Instantiating a parametric class within a specialized context”; application Ser. No. 17/571,353, filed on Jan. 7, 2022 titled “Accessing a parametric field within a specialized context”; application Ser. No. 17/571,356, filed on Jan. 7, 2022 titled “Implementing a type restriction that restricts to a non-polymorphic layout type or a maximum value”; application Ser. No. 17/571,359, filed on Jan. 7, 2022 titled “Implementing a type restriction that restricts to a singleton value or zero values” and application Ser. No. 17/571,379, filed on Jan. 7, 2022 titled “Implementing a type restriction that restricts to a maximum or specific element count”, each of which is hereby incorporated by reference.

## TECHNICAL FIELD

(2) The present disclosure relates to parametric constants and application programming interface (API) points. In particular, the present disclosure relates to determining different resolution states for a parametric constant in different contexts.

## BACKGROUND

(3) Compilers for different programming languages may perform different types of compilations. In some instances, a compiler converts source code, which is written according to a specification directed to the convenience of the programmer, to machine or object code. Machine or object code is executable directly by the particular machine environment. In other instances, a compiler converts source code to an intermediate representation (also known as “virtual machine code” or “virtual machine instructions”), such as bytecode, which is executable by a virtual machine that is capable of running on top of a variety of particular machine environments. The virtual machine instructions are executable by the virtual machine in a more direct and efficient manner than the source code. Converting source code to virtual machine instructions includes mapping source code functionality from the language to virtual machine functionality that utilizes underlying resources, such as data structures. Often, functionality that is presented in simple terms via source code by the programmer is converted into more complex steps that map more directly to the instruction set supported by the underlying hardware on which the virtual machine resides.

(4) A set of code includes a set of application programming interface (API) points. An API point is a named class, interface, method, constructor, or field. Generics enable types (classes and interfaces) to be parameters when defining API points. A parametric API point is an API point that is parameterized over types.

(5) The approaches described in this section are approaches that could be pursued, but not necessarily approaches that have been previously conceived or pursued. Therefore, unless otherwise indicated, it should not be assumed that any of the approaches described in this section qualify as prior art merely by virtue of their inclusion in this section.

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## Description

### BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) The embodiments are illustrated by way of example and not by way of limitation in the figures of the accompanying drawings. It should be noted that references to “an” or “one” embodiment in this disclosure are not necessarily to the same embodiment, and they mean at least one. In the drawings:

(2) FIG. 1 illustrates an example computing architecture in which techniques described herein may be practiced.

(3) FIG. 2 is a block diagram illustrating one embodiment of a computer system suitable for implementing methods and features described herein.

(4) FIG. 3 illustrates an example virtual machine memory layout in block diagram form according to an embodiment.

(5) FIG. 4 illustrates an example frame in block diagram form according to an embodiment.

(6) FIGS. 5A-5B illustrate state machines for constants, and in particular, parametric constants, according to an embodiment.

(7) FIG. 6 illustrates runtime data areas storing information for constants, including parametric constants, according to an embodiment.

(8) FIG. 7 illustrates a call stack storing information for constants, including parametric constants, according to an embodiment.

(9) FIG. 8 illustrates a class file including one or more parametric API points according to an embodiment.

- (10) FIG. 9 illustrates information structures for a specialization anchor constant and a specialization linkage constant according to an embodiment.
- (11) FIGS. 10A-10B illustrate state machines for a specialization anchor constant and a specialization linkage constant according to an embodiment.
- (12) FIG. 11 illustrates storage of an anchor value included in resolved values for resolution states of a specialization anchor constant and a specialization linkage constant according to an embodiment.
- (13) FIG. 12A illustrates an unspecialized type and a specialized type that is the unspecialized type specialized within a particular context according to an embodiment.
- (14) FIG. 12B illustrates an object of a specialized type according to an embodiment.
- (15) FIG. 13 illustrates a resolved value, namely an anchor value, for a resolution state of a specialization anchor constant according to an embodiment.
- (16) FIG. 14 illustrates encapsulation of specialization decisions via restrictions on loadable values of specialization linkage constants according to an embodiment.
- (17) FIG. 15 illustrates a call to a parametric API point according to an embodiment.
- (18) FIG. 16 illustrates an example set of operations for preparing and resolving a type in a runtime environment, including preparing and resolving a parametric constant within a default context, according to an embodiment.
- (19) FIG. 17 illustrates an example set of operations for executing a parametric API point within a particular context, including selecting a resolution state of a parametric constant associated with the particular context, according to an embodiment.
- (20) FIG. 18 illustrates an example set of operations for preparing and resolving a parametric constant within particular contexts provided by calls to parametric API points dependent on the parametric constant according to an embodiment.
- (21) FIG. 19 illustrates an example set of operations for determining an anchor value for a resolution state of an anchor constant according to an embodiment.
- (22) FIG. 20 illustrates an example set of operations for executing an invocation instruction to invoke a parametric method according to an embodiment.
- (23) FIG. 21 illustrates an example set of operations for executing a creation instruction to create an instance of a parametric type according to an embodiment.
- (24) FIG. 22 illustrates an example set of operations for executing an access instruction to access a parametric field according to an embodiment.
- (25) FIG. 23 illustrates a system in accordance with one or more embodiments.

#### DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(26) In the following description, for the purposes of explanation, numerous specific details are set forth in order to provide a thorough understanding. One or more embodiments may be practiced without these specific details. Features described in one embodiment may be combined with features described in a different embodiment. In some examples, well-known structures and devices are described with reference to a block diagram form in order to avoid unnecessarily obscuring the present invention.

1. GENERAL OVERVIEW  
2. ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW  
2.1 EXAMPLE CLASS FILE STRUCTURE  
2.2 EXAMPLE VIRTUAL MACHINE ARCHITECTURE  
2.3 LOADING, LINKING, AND INITIALIZING  
3. PARAMETRIC CONSTANTS  
4. PARAMETRIC APPLICATION PROGRAMMING INTERFACE (API) POINTS  
5. RESOLVING A SPECIALIZATION ANCHOR CONSTANT AND A SPECIALIZATION LINKAGE CONSTANT  
6. EXECUTING PARAMETRIC API POINTS WITHIN PARTICULAR CONTEXTS  
7. EXAMPLE EMBODIMENTS  
7.1 EXECUTING A PARAMETRIC METHOD DEPENDENT ON AN ANCHOR CONSTANT  
7.2 CREATING AN INSTANCE OF A PARAMETRIC CLASS DEPENDENT ON AN ANCHOR CONSTANT  
7.3 ACCESSING A PARAMETRIC FIELD DEPENDENT ON AN ANCHOR CONSTANT  
8. MISCELLANEOUS; EXTENSIONS  
9. HARDWARE OVERVIEW

## 1. GENERAL OVERVIEW

(27) One or more embodiments include determining different resolution states for a parametric constant in different contexts. An invariant constant has at most one value. A state machine for an invariant constant includes an initial unresolved state and then a resolution state, and no other states. When an invariant constant is prepared, the invariant constant assumes the unresolved state. When an invariant constant is resolved, the invariant constant transitions to the resolution state. The value (whether a resolved value or an error) determined for the resolution state is not changeable. An invariant constant can be prepared at most once; hence the invariant constant can assume at most one value. In contrast, a parametric constant can be associated with multiple values, each value being the parametric constant's sole value within a respective context. A state machine for a parametric constant is similar to that for an invariant constant—the state machine includes two states, an unresolved state and a resolution state. The value determined for each resolution state is not changeable. However, a parametric constant be prepared multiple times. Each preparation corresponds to at most a single resolution. Each unresolved state transitions into at most a single resolution state. Different resolution states are associated with different contexts; however the value determined for each resolution state is not changeable and therefore constant for each context. Further, a constant (whether invariant or parametric) is associated with at most one bootstrap method. A bootstrap method determines a resolved value for a resolution state of a constant. For a parametric constant, the same bootstrap method is executed for different resolutions, but each execution receives different contexts as input.

(28) A context for a parametric constant is information relevant to determining a resolved value for the parametric constant that is supplied by a user of the parametric constant. A user of the parametric constant may be, for example, a caller of an application programming interface (API) point that depends on the parametric constant. The context is applicable and unchangeable during the execution of the API point. Hence the context is applicable and unchangeable while within a stack frame, on a call stack, corresponding to the execution of the API point. As described above, each context corresponds to at most one resolution state, and one resolved value, of a parametric constant. Therefore all operations within the stack frame corresponding to the execution of the API point can access at most one resolution state, and one resolved value, of the parametric constant. Within the stack frame corresponding to the execution of the API point, the parametric constant has a single constant value. Indeed, within any stack frame corresponding to execution of any API point depending on the same parametric constant, wherein each respective caller supplies the same context, the parametric constant has a single constant value. However, within different stack frame corresponding to executions of the same API point within different contexts, operations of different stack frames access different resolution states, and different resolved values, of the same parametric constant.

(29) A per-type runtime constant pool stores a set of constants for a type. A per-type runtime constant pool includes a single invariant runtime constant pool, storing invariant constants, and zero or more parametric runtime constant pool, storing parametric constants. For a particular parametric constant, at most a single resolution state is stored in each parametric runtime constant pool. A parametric runtime constant pool storing a resolution state of a parametric constant relevant to one or more contexts is also associated with the same one or more contexts. (While a context is associated with at most one resolution state of a particular parametric constant, a resolution state may be associated with one or more contexts.) Therefore, different parametric runtime constant pools associated with the same parametric constant are associated with different contexts. As used herein, the term “runtime constant pool” may refer to a per-type runtime constant pool, an invariant runtime constant pool, and/or a parametric runtime constant pool.

(30) Each stack frame is associated with a constant pool reference, pointing to a per-type runtime constant pool for a type defining (or inheriting) the API point being executed. Operations within a stack frame access resolution states of constants from the per-type runtime constant pool that is

referenced by the stack frame's constant pool reference. A constant pool reference includes one component pointing to the invariant runtime constant pool for a particular type. Additionally the constant pool reference includes another component pointing to a parametric runtime constant pool associated with the particular type. While potentially multiple parametric runtime constant pools are associated with the particular type, the referenced parametric runtime constant pool corresponds to the same context that is applicable to the stack frame. Since a stack frame is associated with at most one of a set of contexts associated with a particular parametric constant, and a context is associated with at most one parametric runtime constant pool associated with the particular parametric constant, therefore at most one parametric runtime constant pool associated with the particular parametric constant is accessed for the duration of each stack frame; no other parametric runtime constant pool associated with the particular parametric constant is accessed.

(31) One or more embodiments include determining a resolution state of a specialization anchor constant (also referred to as an “anchor constant”) on which an API point depends. An anchor constant is a parametric constant. An API point that depends on a parametric constant may be referred to as a “parametric API point.” A resolved value for a resolution state of an anchor constant stores a set of specialization decisions for the parametric API point within a particular context. A resolved value for a resolution state of an anchor constant may be referred to herein as a “specialization anchor value,” or “anchor value.” An anchor value may be stored in the form of an object of a particular type, referred to herein as a “specialization anchor type,” or “anchor type.”

(32) An “unspecialized type” is a type that defines one or more API points. An unspecialized type may specify that a particular API point (defined by the unspecialized type itself, or defined by a supertype of the unspecialized type and inherited by the unspecialized type) is dependent on an anchor constant, thereby rendering the particular API point parametric. The unspecialized type thereby also depends on the anchor constant and is parametric.

(33) A “specialized type” is a type resulting from specializing a parametric unspecialized type within a particular context. The specialized type is the parametric unspecialized type adorned with specialization decisions (which may be embodied in an anchor value). The parametric unspecialized type may be referred to as an “underlying unspecialized type” for the specialized type. Although the specialized type itself does not define or declare any fields and methods, the specialized type has the same fields and methods as the underlying unspecialized type. The fields and methods of the specialized type are the same as the fields and methods of the underlying unspecialized type, but the fields and methods of the specialized type are further adorned with specialization decisions.

(34) Specialization decisions may include type restrictions on fields, method parameters, and/or method return values. A type restriction on an API point in a specialized type prohibits the API point from assuming one or more values that are originally valid for a type of the same API point as specified by the underlying unspecialized type.

(35) Additionally or alternatively, specialization decisions may include a different memory layout and/or memory size for a specialized type relative to the underlying unspecialized type. As an example, an unspecialized type may specify that a field is of the type Object. Hence a memory space for the field stores a reference value, which may require 8 bytes. A specialized type may include a type restriction on the field, restricting the field to values of int. Values of int may be stored inline and require only 4 bytes. Hence, a memory layout associated with the specialized type may include inlining the int value for the field within an instance of the specialized type. Further, a memory size associated with the specialized type may be 4 bytes less than a memory size associated with the unspecialized type.

(36) Based on specialization decisions, further customizations and/or optimizations may be performed. Memory flattening optimizations refer to storing a value in place of a reference to the value, also referred to as “inlining.” The value may be associated with a field, method parameter, and/or method return value. The inlining may occur in local variables in a call frame, an operand

stack, and/or the passing of values between a callee method and a caller method. Type sharpening optimizations refer to eliding certain operations of a method. As an example, a method may specify that different operations are performed based on a type of a method parameter. For example, (37) TABLE-US-00001 void m(T t) { if (t instanceof String) { a(t); } else b (t); } When specializing to T=String, the type test and the else-arm are elided; when specializing to T!=String, the type test and the if-arm are elided.

(38) As described above, an anchor value stores a set of specialization decisions, within a particular context, for an API point that depends on an anchor constant. The particular context is associated with a specialization proposal supplied by the caller of the API point. The proposal is specified by the caller using an operand of an instruction that calls the API point. The operand is a specialization linkage constant (also referred to as a “linkage constant”). The linkage constant is a wrapper around the API point and a specialization selector value (also referred to as a “selector value”). The selector value indicates the caller's specialization proposal for the API point.

(39) A linkage constant is initially in an unresolved state. The linkage constant wraps around a parametric API point (specifically, a symbolic reference to the parametric API point) and a selector value. If the selector value is unvalidated, resolving the linkage constant includes resolving an anchor constant on which the parametric API point depends. Resolving the anchor constant includes verifying whether the proposed selector value is valid for the anchor constant. The callee may accept or reject the selector value. If the selector value is rejected, an error is permanently stored as the resolution state of the anchor constant within the context associated with the selector value. If the selector value is accepted, then the callee determines an anchor value embodying specialization decisions made based on the selector value. The above validation and resolution operations may be embodied in a bootstrap method corresponding to the anchor constant. The anchor value is stored as a resolved value for a resolution state of the anchor constant. Then both the parametric API point (specifically, a direct reference to the parametric API point) and the anchor value are stored as a resolved value for a resolution state of the linkage constant. The parametric API point is then executed based on the anchor value.

(40) Alternatively, a linkage constant in an unresolved state may wrap around a validated selector value. A selector value is validated if the selector value matches an anchor value previously resolved for the anchor constant on which the parametric API point depends. The parametric API point is then executed based on the matching anchor value.

(41) As described above, a resolved linkage constant wraps around a parametric API point and an anchor value. The resolved linkage constant may be used in a subsequent call to any parametric API point dependent on the same anchor constant. The called parametric API point is then executed based on the anchor value indicated by the resolved linkage constant.

(42) One or more embodiments include executing a parametric method within a particular context. An invocation instruction to invoke a parametric method supplies a context. Information indicating the context (such as an anchor value) is passed from a stack frame associated with the caller to a stack frame associated with the callee. Hence, the context applicable to execution of the parametric method is accessible to operations within the stack frame associated with the callee.

(43) In an embodiment, a context is associated with a type restriction on a method parameter and/or method return value. Hence, during execution of the parametric method, the method parameter and/or method return value is processed based on the type restriction. Processing a method parameter and/or method return value based on a type restriction may include type checking the method parameter and/or method return value based on the type restriction, and/or converting or casting the method parameter and/or method return value based on the type restriction. Additionally or alternatively, processing a method parameter and/or method return value based on a type restriction may include performing certain optimizations including memory flattening and/or stack flattening, such as modifying a memory size for the method parameter and/or method return value based on the type restriction, and/or inlining the method parameter and/or method return value

based on the type restriction.

(44) In an embodiment, a context is associated with one of a plurality of parametric runtime constant pools associated with an anchor constant on which a parametric method depends. Each of the plurality of parametric runtime constant pools stores a respective resolution state for the anchor constant. Hence, a constant pool reference of a stack frame corresponding to execution of the parametric method within a particular context points to the parametric runtime constant pool associated with the same particular context. Operations within the stack frame access a resolution state for the anchor constant, and resolution states for zero or more other constants dependent on the anchor constant, from the referenced parametric runtime constant pool; no other parametric runtime constant pool associated with the anchor constant is accessed within the stack frame. The parametric method may be executed using the resolution states within the referenced parametric runtime constant pool, without using resolution states within any other parametric runtime constant pool associated with the anchor constant.

(45) One or more embodiments include creating an object of a specialized type. Generating an object involves the steps of allocating memory space to the object and initializing the object. Generating an object of a specialized type involves (a) allocating memory space based on a memory size and/or memory layout associated with the specialized type, and (b) initializing the object based on the underlying unspecialized type.

(46) In an embodiment, different instructions perform memory allocation and initialization—a creation instruction causes memory allocation; an invocation instruction to invoke a constructor causes initialization. Each creation instruction corresponds to an invocation instruction to generate respective objects. To generate an object of a specialized type, a creation instruction supplies (a) an unspecialized type (that depends on an anchor constant and is therefore parametric) and (b) a context for specializing the unspecialized type that results in the specialized type. A memory space is allocated for the object based on a memory size and/or memory layout associated with the specialized type. The anchor value, resolved for the anchor constant, may indicate the memory size and/or memory layout associated with the specialized type. Further, an invocation instruction corresponding to the creation instruction invokes a constructor defined in the unspecialized type, or a supertype of the underlying unspecialized type. If the constructor depends on the anchor constant (and/or other parametric constants), the invocation instruction may further supply a context for invoking the constructor.

(47) In an embodiment, metadata of an object indicates a type of the object. Metadata of an object of a specialized type indicates the specialized type of the object. The specialized type thus indicated may be referred to as a “recorded specialized type” for the object. In particular, metadata of an object of a specialized type may include a reference to an object (such as a class mirror) representing the specialized type. The anchor value, resolved for the anchor constant on which the unspecialized type depends, may indicate a reference to the object representing the specialized type.

(48) One or more embodiments include accessing a parametric field of an object within a particular context. An access instruction to access a parametric field of an object supplies a context. The context is associated with a specialized type expected of the object. The expected specialized type is verified against a recorded specialized type of the object. If a match is found, then the field is accessed based on a memory layout associated with the recorded specialized type. If no match is found, then the field is accessed based on a different memory layout, such as a memory layout associated with a default context, or an error is generated.

(49) In an embodiment, a field is associated with a name and a type. An invariant type defines both the name and type of a field of the invariant type. The invariant type is referred to as a “containing type” for the field. However, different types define the name and type of a specialized field of a specialized type. The underlying unspecialized type defines the name of the specialized field; the specialized type defines the type of the specialized field. The specialized type specializes the type

of the specialized field within a particular context based on a type restriction applicable to the field with the particular context. A value for the specialized field is type checked, converted, and/or casted based on the type restriction. Hence, the specialized field may be referred to as having two “containing types,” a “specialized containing type” and an “unspecialized containing type.”

(50) In an embodiment, access instructions of different instruction types are used to operate on values of different types. Such access instructions may include virtual machine instructions and/or machine code. Access instructions of different instruction types are used to access a same parametric field within different contexts, because the parametric field is associated with different specialized field types within different contexts. An instruction type of an access instruction to a parametric field is determined based on a type restriction applicable within a particular context. As an example, an unspecialized type may specify that a field is of the type Object, such that a memory space for the field stores a reference (to a memory address in heap) rather than a data value. A specialized type may include a type restriction on the field, restricting the field to values of int. An access instruction to access the field in the specialized type may be of the type int (such as, iload). An access instruction to access the field in the unspecialized type may be of the type corresponding to references (such as, aload).

(51) One or more embodiments described in this Specification and/or recited in the claims may not be included in this General Overview section.

## 2. ARCHITECTURAL OVERVIEW

(52) FIG. 1 illustrates an example architecture in which techniques described herein may be practiced. Software and/or hardware components described with relation to the example architecture may be omitted or associated with a different set of functionality than described herein. Software and/or hardware components, not described herein, may be used within an environment in accordance with one or more embodiments. Accordingly, the example environment should not be constructed as limiting the scope of any of the claims.

(53) As illustrated in FIG. 1, a computing architecture **100** includes source code files **101** which are compiled by a compiler **102** into class files **103** representing the program to be executed. The class files **103** are then loaded and executed by an execution platform **112**, which includes a runtime environment **113**, an operating system **111**, and one or more application programming interfaces (APIs) **110** that enable communication between the runtime environment **113** and the operating system **111**. The runtime environment **113** includes a virtual machine **104** comprising various components, such as a memory manager **105** (which may include a garbage collector), a class file verifier **106** to check the validity of class files **103**, a class loader **107** to locate and build in-memory representations of classes, an interpreter **108** for executing the virtual machine **104** code, and a just-in-time (JIT) compiler **109** for producing optimized machine-level code.

(54) In an embodiment, the computing architecture **100** includes source code files **101** that contain code that has been written in a particular programming language, such as Java, C, C++, C#, Ruby, Perl, and so forth. Thus, the source code files **101** adhere to a particular set of syntactic and/or semantic rules for the associated language. For example, code written in Java adheres to the Java Language Specification. However, since specifications are updated and revised over time, the source code files **101** may be associated with a version number indicating the revision of the specification to which the source code files **101** adhere. The exact programming language used to write the source code files **101** is generally not critical.

(55) In various embodiments, the compiler **102** converts the source code, which is written according to a specification directed to the convenience of the programmer, to either machine or object code, which is executable directly by the particular machine environment, or an intermediate representation (“virtual machine code/instructions”), such as bytecode, which is executable by a virtual machine **104** that is capable of running on top of a variety of particular machine environments. The virtual machine instructions are executable by the virtual machine **104** in a more direct and efficient manner than the source code. Converting source code to virtual machine

instructions includes mapping source code functionality from the language to virtual machine functionality that utilizes underlying resources, such as data structures. Often, functionality that is presented in simple terms via source code by the programmer is converted into more complex steps that map more directly to the instruction set supported by the underlying hardware on which the virtual machine **104** resides.

(56) In general, programs are executed either as a compiled or an interpreted program. When a program is compiled, the code is transformed globally from a first language to a second language before execution. Since the work of transforming the code is performed ahead of time; compiled code tends to have excellent run-time performance. In addition, since the transformation occurs globally before execution, the code can be analyzed and optimized using techniques such as constant folding, dead code elimination, inlining, and so forth. However, depending on the program being executed, the startup time can be significant. In addition, inserting new code would require the program to be taken offline, re-compiled, and re-executed. For many dynamic languages (such as Java) which are designed to allow code to be inserted during the program's execution, a purely compiled approach may be inappropriate. When a program is interpreted, the code of the program is read line-by-line and converted to machine-level instructions while the program is executing. As a result, the program has a short startup time (can begin executing almost immediately), but the run-time performance is diminished by performing the transformation on the fly. Furthermore, since each instruction is analyzed individually, many optimizations that rely on a more global analysis of the program cannot be performed.

(57) In some embodiments, the virtual machine **104** includes an interpreter **108** and a JIT compiler **109** (or a component implementing aspects of both), and executes programs using a combination of interpreted and compiled techniques. For example, the virtual machine **104** may initially begin by interpreting the virtual machine instructions representing the program via the interpreter **108** while tracking statistics related to program behavior, such as how often different sections or blocks of code are executed by the virtual machine **104**. Once a block of code surpasses a threshold (is “hot”), the virtual machine **104** invokes the JIT compiler **109** to perform an analysis of the block and generate optimized machine-level instructions which replaces the “hot” block of code for future executions. Since programs tend to spend most time executing a small portion of overall code, compiling just the “hot” portions of the program can provide similar performance to fully compiled code, but without the start-up penalty. Furthermore, although the optimization analysis is constrained to the “hot” block being replaced, there still exists far greater optimization potential than converting each instruction individually. There are a number of variations on the above described example, such as tiered compiling.

(58) In order to provide clear examples, the source code files **101** have been illustrated as the “top level” representation of the program to be executed by the execution platform **112**. Although the computing architecture **100** depicts the source code files **101** as a “top level” program representation, in other embodiments the source code files **101** may be an intermediate representation received via a “higher level” compiler that processed code files in a different language into the language of the source code files **101**. Some examples in the following disclosure assume that the source code files **101** adhere to a class-based object-oriented programming language. However, this is not a requirement to utilizing the features described herein.

(59) In an embodiment, compiler **102** receives as input the source code files **101** and converts the source code files **101** into class files **103** that are in a format expected by the virtual machine **104**. For example, in the context of the JVM, the Java Virtual Machine Specification defines a particular class file format to which the class files **103** are expected to adhere. In some embodiments, the class files **103** contain the virtual machine instructions that have been converted from the source code files **101**. However, in other embodiments, the class files **103** may contain other structures as well, such as tables identifying constant values and/or metadata related to various structures (classes, fields, methods, and so forth).

(60) The following discussion assumes that each of the class files **103** represents a respective “class” defined in the source code files **101** (or dynamically generated by the compiler **102**/virtual machine **104**). However, the aforementioned assumption is not a strict requirement and will depend on the implementation of the virtual machine **104**. Thus, the techniques described herein may still be performed regardless of the exact format of the class files **103**. In some embodiments, the class files **103** are divided into one or more “libraries” or “packages”, each of which includes a collection of classes that provide related functionality. For example, a library may contain one or more class files that implement input/output (I/O) operations, mathematics tools, cryptographic techniques, graphics utilities, and so forth. Further, some classes (or fields/methods within those classes) may include access restrictions that limit their use to within a particular class/library/package or to classes with appropriate permissions.

#### (61) 2.1 Example Class File Structure

(62) FIG. 2 illustrates an example structure for a class file **200** in block diagram form according to an embodiment. In order to provide clear examples, the remainder of the disclosure assumes that the class files **103** of the computing architecture **100** adhere to the structure of the example class file **200** described in this section. However, in a practical environment, the structure of the class file **200** will be dependent on the implementation of the virtual machine **104**. Further, one or more features discussed herein may modify the structure of the class file **200** to, for example, add additional structure types. Therefore, the exact structure of the class file **200** is not critical to the techniques described herein. For the purposes of Section 2.1, “the class” or “the present class” refers to the class represented by the class file **200**.

(63) In FIG. 2, the class file **200** includes a constant table **201**, field structures **208**, class structures **204**, and method structures **209**. In an embodiment, the constant table **201** is a data structure which, among other functions, acts as a symbol table for the class. For example, the constant table **201** may store data related to the various identifiers used in the source code files **101** such as type, scope, contents, and/or location. The constant table **201** has entries for value structures **202** (representing constant values of type int, long, double, float, byte, string, and so forth), class information structures **203**, name and type information structures **205**, field reference structures **206**, and method reference structures **207** derived from the source code files **101** by the compiler **102**. In an embodiment, the constant table **201** is implemented as an array that maps an index *i* to structure *j*. However, the exact implementation of the constant table **201** is not critical.

(64) In some embodiments, the entries of the constant table **201** include structures which index other constant table **201** entries. For example, an entry for one of the value structures **202** representing a string may hold a tag identifying its “type” as string and an index to one or more other value structures **202** of the constant table **201** storing char, byte or int values representing the ASCII characters of the string.

(65) In an embodiment, field reference structures **206** of the constant table **201** hold an index into the constant table **201** to one of the class information structures **203** representing the class defining the field and an index into the constant table **201** to one of the name and type information structures **205** that provides the name and descriptor of the field. Method reference structures **207** of the constant table **201** hold an index into the constant table **201** to one of the class information structures **203** representing the class defining the method and an index into the constant table **201** to one of the name and type information structures **205** that provides the name and descriptor for the method. The class information structures **203** hold an index into the constant table **201** to one of the value structures **202** holding the name of the associated class.

(66) The name and type information structures **205** hold an index into the constant table **201** to one of the value structures **202** storing the name of the field/method and an index into the constant table **201** to one of the value structures **202** storing the descriptor.

(67) In an embodiment, class structures **204** (also referred to as “class metadata”) includes metadata for the class, such as version number(s), number of entries in the constant pool, number

of fields, number of methods, access flags (whether the class is public, private, final, abstract, etc.), an index to one of the class information structures **203** of the constant table **201** that identifies the present class, an index to one of the class information structures **203** of the constant table **201** that identifies the superclass (if any), and so forth.

(68) In an embodiment, the field structures **208** represent a set of structures that identifies the various fields of the class. The field structures **208** store, for each field of the class, accessor flags for the field (whether the field is static, public, private, final, etc.), an index into the constant table **201** to one of the value structures **202** that holds the name of the field, and an index into the constant table **201** to one of the value structures **202** that holds a descriptor of the field.

(69) In an embodiment, the method structures **209** represent a set of structures that identifies the various methods of the class. The method structures **209** store, for each method of the class, accessor flags for the method (e.g. whether the method is static, public, private, synchronized, etc.), an index into the constant table **201** to one of the value structures **202** that holds the name of the method, an index into the constant table **201** to one of the value structures **202** that holds the descriptor of the method, and the virtual machine instructions that correspond to the body of the method as defined in the source code files **101**.

(70) In an embodiment, a descriptor represents a type of a field or method. For example, the descriptor may be implemented as a string adhering to a particular syntax. While the exact syntax is not critical, a few examples are described below.

(71) In an example where the descriptor represents a type of the field, the descriptor identifies the type of data held by the field. In an embodiment, a field can hold a basic type, an object, or an array. When a field holds a basic type, the descriptor is a string that identifies the basic type (e.g., “B”=byte, “C”=char, “D”=double, “F”=float, “I”=int, “J”=long int, etc.). When a field holds an object, the descriptor is a string that identifies the class name of the object (e.g. “L ClassName”). “L” in this case indicates a reference, thus “L ClassName” represents a reference to an object of class ClassName. When the field is an array, the descriptor identifies the type held by the array. For example, “[B” indicates an array of bytes, with “[” indicating an array and “B” indicating that the array holds the basic type of byte. However, since arrays can be nested, the descriptor for an array may also indicate the nesting. For example, “[L ClassName” indicates an array where each index holds an array that holds objects of class ClassName. In some embodiments, the ClassName is fully qualified and includes the simple name of the class, as well as the pathname of the class. For example, the ClassName may indicate where the file is stored in the package, library, or file system hosting the class file **200**.

(72) In the case of a method, the descriptor identifies the parameters of the method and the return type of the method. For example, a method descriptor may follow the general form “({ParameterDescriptor}) ReturnDescriptor”, where the {ParameterDescriptor} is a list of field descriptors representing the parameters and the ReturnDescriptor is a field descriptor identifying the return type. For instance, the string “V” may be used to represent the void return type. Thus, a method defined in the source code files **101** as “Object m(int I, double d, Thread t) { . . . }” matches the descriptor “(I D L Thread) L Object”.

(73) In an embodiment, the virtual machine instructions held in the method structures **209** include operations which reference entries of the constant table **201**. Using Java as an example, consider the following class:

(74) TABLE-US-00002 class A {   int add12and13( ) {       return B.addTwo(12, 13);   } }

(75) In the above example, the Java method add12and13 is defined in class A, takes no parameters, and returns an integer. The body of method add12and13 calls static method addTwo of class B which takes the constant integer values 12 and 13 as parameters, and returns the result. Thus, in the constant table **201**, the compiler **102** includes, among other entries, a method reference structure that corresponds to the call to the method B.addTwo. In Java, a call to a method compiles down to an invoke command in the bytecode of the JVM (in this case invokestatic as addTwo is a static

method of class B). The invoke command is provided an index into the constant table **201** corresponding to the method reference structure that identifies the class defining addTwo “B”, the name of addTwo “addTwo”, and the descriptor of addTwo “(I I)”. For example, assuming the aforementioned method reference is stored at index **4**, the bytecode instruction may appear as “invokestatic #4”.

(76) Since the constant table **201** refers to classes, methods, and fields symbolically with structures carrying identifying information, rather than direct references to a memory location, the entries of the constant table **201** are referred to as “symbolic references”. One reason that symbolic references are utilized for the class files **103** is because, in some embodiments, the compiler **102** is unaware of how and where the classes will be stored once loaded into the runtime environment **113**. As will be described in Section 2.3, eventually the run-time representations of the symbolic references are resolved into actual memory addresses by the virtual machine **104** after the referenced classes (and associated structures) have been loaded into the runtime environment and allocated concrete memory locations.

(77) 2.2 Example Virtual Machine Architecture

(78) FIG. 3 illustrates an example virtual machine memory layout **300** in block diagram form according to an embodiment. In order to provide clear examples, the remaining discussion will assume that the virtual machine **104** adheres to the virtual machine memory layout **300** depicted in FIG. 3. In addition, although components of the virtual machine memory layout **300** may be referred to as memory “areas”, there is no requirement that the memory areas are contiguous.

(79) In the example illustrated by FIG. 3, the virtual machine memory layout **300** is divided into a shared area **301** and a thread area **307**. The shared area **301** represents an area in memory where structures shared among the various threads executing on the virtual machine **104** are stored. The shared area **301** includes a heap **302** and a per-class area **303**. In an embodiment, the heap **302** represents the run-time data area from which memory for class instances and arrays is allocated. In an embodiment, the per-class area **303** represents the memory area where the data pertaining to the individual classes are stored. In an embodiment, the per-class area **303** includes, for each loaded class, a run-time constant pool **304** representing data from the constant table **201** of the class, field and method data **306** (for example, to hold the static fields of the class), and the method code **305** representing the virtual machine instructions for methods of the class.

(80) The thread area **307** represents a memory area where structures specific to individual threads are stored. In FIG. 3, the thread area **307** includes thread structures **308** and thread structures **311**, representing the per-thread structures utilized by different threads. In order to provide clear examples, the thread area **307** depicted in FIG. 3 assumes two threads are executing on the virtual machine **104**. However, in a practical environment, the virtual machine **104** may execute any arbitrary number of threads, with the number of thread structures scaled accordingly.

(81) In an embodiment, thread structures **308** includes program counter **309** and virtual machine stack **310**. Similarly, thread structures **311** includes program counter **312** and virtual machine stack **313**. In an embodiment, program counter **309** and program counter **312** store the current address of the virtual machine instruction being executed by their respective threads.

(82) Thus, as a thread steps through the instructions, the program counters are updated to maintain an index to the current instruction. In an embodiment, virtual machine stack **310** and virtual machine stack **313** each store frames for their respective threads that hold local variables and partial results, and is also used for method invocation and return.

(83) In an embodiment, a frame is a data structure used to store data and partial results, return values for methods, and perform dynamic linking. A new frame is created each time a method is invoked. A frame is destroyed when the method that caused the frame to be generated completes. Thus, when a thread performs a method invocation, the virtual machine **104** generates a new frame and pushes that frame onto the virtual machine stack associated with the thread.

(84) When the method invocation completes, the virtual machine **104** passes back the result of the

method invocation to the previous frame and pops the current frame off of the stack. In an embodiment, for a given thread, one frame is active at any point. This active frame is referred to as the current frame, the method that caused generation of the current frame is referred to as the current method, and the class to which the current method belongs is referred to as the current class.

(85) FIG. 4 illustrates an example frame **400** in block diagram form according to an embodiment. In order to provide clear examples, the remaining discussion will assume that frames of virtual machine stack **310** and virtual machine stack **313** adhere to the structure of frame **400**.

(86) In an embodiment, frame **400** includes local variables **401**, operand stack **402**, and run-time constant pool reference table **403**. In an embodiment, the local variables **401** are represented as an array of variables that each hold a value, for example, Boolean, byte, char, short, int, float, or reference. Further, some value types, such as longs or doubles, may be represented by more than one entry in the array. The local variables **401** are used to pass parameters on method invocations and store partial results. For example, when generating the frame **400** in response to invoking a method, the parameters may be stored in predefined positions within the local variables **401**, such as indexes **1-N** corresponding to the first to Nth parameters in the invocation.

(87) In an embodiment, the operand stack **402** is empty by default when the frame **400** is created by the virtual machine **104**. The virtual machine **104** then supplies instructions from the method code **305** of the current method to load constants or values from the local variables **401** onto the operand stack **402**. Other instructions take operands from the operand stack **402**, operate on them, and push the result back onto the operand stack **402**. Furthermore, the operand stack **402** is used to prepare parameters to be passed to methods and to receive method results. For example, the parameters of the method being invoked could be pushed onto the operand stack **402** prior to issuing the invocation to the method. The virtual machine **104** then generates a new frame for the method invocation where the operands on the operand stack **402** of the previous frame are popped and loaded into the local variables **401** of the new frame. When the invoked method terminates, the new frame is popped from the virtual machine stack and the return value is pushed onto the operand stack **402** of the previous frame.

(88) In an embodiment, the run-time constant pool reference table **403** contains a reference to the run-time constant pool **304** of the current class. The run-time constant pool reference table **403** is used to support resolution. Resolution is the process whereby symbolic references in the constant pool **304** are translated into concrete memory addresses, loading classes as necessary to resolve as-yet-undefined symbols and translating variable accesses into appropriate offsets into storage structures associated with the run-time location of these variables.

(89) 2.3 Loading, Linking, and Initializing

(90) In an embodiment, the virtual machine **104** dynamically loads, links, and initializes classes. Loading is the process of finding a class with a particular name and creating a representation from the associated class file **200** of that class within the memory of the runtime environment **113**. For example, creating the run-time constant pool **304**, method code **305**, and field and method data **306** for the class within the per-class area **303** of the virtual machine memory layout **300**. Linking is the process of taking the in-memory representation of the class and combining it with the run-time state of the virtual machine **104** so that the methods of the class can be executed. Initialization is the process of executing the class constructors to set the starting state of the field and method data **306** of the class and/or create class instances on the heap **302** for the initialized class.

(91) The following are examples of loading, linking, and initializing techniques that may be implemented by the virtual machine **104**. However, in many embodiments the steps may be interleaved, such that an initial class is loaded, then during linking a second class is loaded to resolve a symbolic reference found in the first class, which in turn causes a third class to be loaded, and so forth. Thus, progress through the stages of loading, linking, and initializing can differ from class to class. Further, some embodiments may delay (perform “lazily”) one or more functions of

the loading, linking, and initializing process until the class is actually required. For example, resolution of a method reference may be delayed until a virtual machine instruction invoking the method is executed. Thus, the exact timing of when the steps are performed for each class can vary greatly between implementations.

(92) To begin the loading process, the virtual machine **104** starts up by invoking the class loader **107** which loads an initial class. The technique by which the initial class is specified will vary from embodiment to embodiment. For example, one technique may have the virtual machine **104** accept a command line argument on startup that specifies the initial class.

(93) To load a class, the class loader **107** parses the class file **200** corresponding to the class and determines whether the class file **200** is well-formed (meets the syntactic expectations of the virtual machine **104**). If not, the class loader **107** generates an error. For example, in Java the error might be generated in the form of an exception which is thrown to an exception handler for processing. Otherwise, the class loader **107** generates the in-memory representation of the class by allocating the run-time constant pool **304**, method code **305**, and field and method data **306** for the class within the per-class area **303**.

(94) In some embodiments, when the class loader **107** loads a class, the class loader **107** also recursively loads the super-classes of the loaded class. For example, the virtual machine **104** may ensure that the super-classes of a particular class are loaded, linked, and/or initialized before proceeding with the loading, linking and initializing process for the particular class.

(95) During linking, the virtual machine **104** verifies the class, prepares the class, and performs resolution of the symbolic references defined in the run-time constant pool **304** of the class.

(96) To verify the class, the virtual machine **104** checks whether the in-memory representation of the class is structurally correct. For example, the virtual machine **104** may check that each class except the generic class Object has a superclass, check that final classes have no sub-classes and final methods are not overridden, check whether constant pool entries are consistent with one another, check whether the current class has correct access permissions for classes/fields/structures referenced in the constant pool **304**, check that the virtual machine **104** code of methods will not cause unexpected behavior (e.g. making sure a jump instruction does not send the virtual machine **104** beyond the end of the method), and so forth. The exact checks performed during verification are dependent on the implementation of the virtual machine **104**. In some cases, verification may cause additional classes to be loaded, but does not necessarily require those classes to also be linked before proceeding. For example, assume Class A contains a reference to a static field of Class B. During verification, the virtual machine **104** may check Class B to ensure that the referenced static field actually exists, which might cause loading of Class B, but not necessarily the linking or initializing of Class B. However, in some embodiments, certain verification checks can be delayed until a later phase, such as being checked during resolution of the symbolic references. For example, some embodiments may delay checking the access permissions for symbolic references until those references are being resolved.

(97) To prepare a class, the virtual machine **104** initializes static fields located within the field and method data **306** for the class to default values. In some cases, setting the static fields to default values may not be the same as running a constructor for the class. For example, the verification process may zero out or set the static fields to values that the constructor would expect those fields to have during initialization.

(98) During resolution, the virtual machine **104** dynamically determines concrete memory address from the symbolic references included in the run-time constant pool **304** of the class. To resolve the symbolic references, the virtual machine **104** utilizes the class loader **107** to load the class identified in the symbolic reference (if not already loaded). Once loaded, the virtual machine **104** has knowledge of the memory location within the per-class area **303** of the referenced class and its fields/methods. The virtual machine **104** then replaces the symbolic references with a reference to the concrete memory location of the referenced class, field, or method. In an embodiment, the

virtual machine **104** caches resolutions to be reused in case the same class/name/descriptor is encountered when the virtual machine **104** processes another class. For example, in some cases, class A and class B may invoke the same method of class C. Thus, when resolution is performed for class A, that result can be cached and reused during resolution of the same symbolic reference in class B to reduce overhead.

(99) In some embodiments, the step of resolving the symbolic references during linking is optional. For example, an embodiment may perform the symbolic resolution in a “lazy” fashion, delaying the step of resolution until a virtual machine instruction that requires the referenced class/method/field is executed.

(100) During initialization, the virtual machine **104** executes the constructor of the class to set the starting state of that class. For example, initialization may initialize the field and method data **306** for the class and generate/initialize any class instances on the heap **302** created by the constructor. For example, the class file **200** for a class may specify that a particular method is a constructor that is used for setting up the starting state. Thus, during initialization, the virtual machine **104** executes the instructions of that constructor.

(101) In some embodiments, the virtual machine **104** performs resolution on field and method references by initially checking whether the field/method is defined in the referenced class. Otherwise, the virtual machine **104** recursively searches through the super-classes of the referenced class for the referenced field/method until the field/method is located, or the top-level superclass is reached, in which case an error is generated.

### 3. PARAMETRIC CONSTANTS

(102) FIGS. 5A-5B illustrate state machines for constants, and in particular, parametric constants, according to an embodiment.

(103) In one or more embodiments, a state machine **500** for a constant includes two states, an unresolved state **502** and a resolution state **504**.

(104) Initially, a constant is prepared. Preparation may be performed during preparation of a type defining the constant. Alternatively, preparation may be triggered by other events. Once the constant is prepared, the constant assumes an unresolved state **502**.

(105) Next, the constant is resolved. Resolution may be performed based on a bootstrap method corresponding to the constant. Alternatively, resolution may be performed based on another method, which may be defined by the runtime environment. Once the constant is resolved, the constant assumes a resolution state **504**. The process of resolution determines a resolved value, or an error, for the resolution state **504**. A resolved value is stored in a heap.

(106) Within a state machine **500**, at most one resolution state **504** corresponds to each unresolved state **502**. At most one resolution step corresponds to each preparation step. Further, no other states follow after the object reaches a resolution state **504**. Once the resolution state **504** is reached, the resolution state **504** is permanent for the constant.

(107) Any value (whether a resolved value or an error) determined for a resolution state **504** is unchangeable for the resolution state **504**. Hence, the resolved value or error is permanent for the resolution state **504** of the constant.

(108) In one or more embodiments, at most one state machine **500** is associated with an invariant constant. Therefore, an invariant constant represents at most one value. In contrast, multiple state machines **516a-b** may be associated with a parametric constant **506**. As illustrated, for example, state machine **516a** includes unresolved state **512a** transitioning to resolution state **514a**; state machine **516b** includes unresolved state **512b** transitioning to resolution state **514b**. State machine **516a-b** associated with a same parametric constant **506** correspond to different contexts. State machines **516a-b** and contexts have a one-to-many relationship: each state machine relates to one or more contexts; each context relates to a single state machine. Based on the multiple state machines **516a-b**, a parametric constant **506** may represent different values across different contexts, but at most one value within each context. The term “constant” as used herein may refer

to an invariant constant and/or parametric constant.

(109) FIG. 6 illustrates runtime data areas storing information for constants, including parametric constants, according to an embodiment.

(110) In one or more embodiments, runtime data areas **600** of a virtual machine include one or more per-type runtime constant pools **602a-b**, and a heap **608**. A per-type runtime constant pool **602a-b** is similar to a runtime constant pool **304** of FIG. 3. A heap **608** is similar to a heap **302** of FIG. 3.

(111) In one or more embodiments, a single per-type runtime constant pool (such as any of per-type runtime constant pools **602a-b**) corresponds to each type loaded in a virtual machine. A per-type runtime constant pool corresponding to a type stores entries for both invariant constants and parametric constants defined by the type. Each resolved entry within a per-type runtime constant pool refers to a respective resolved value (such as any of resolved values **610-616b**).

(112) In an embodiment, a per-type runtime constant pool includes a single invariant runtime constant pool **604**, storing entries for invariant constants defined by the type.

(113) In an embodiment, a per-type runtime constant pool includes zero or more parametric runtime constant pools **606a-b**, storing entries for parametric constants defined by the type.

(114) In an embodiment, a reference to a per-type runtime constant pool within a particular context may include multiple components: a reference to the invariant runtime constant pool and a reference to a parametric runtime constant pool that is relevant to the particular context.

(115) In one or more embodiments, a set of parametric runtime constant pools **606a-b** stores respective resolution states of a particular parametric constant. A parametric runtime constant pool storing a resolution state that is relevant to one or more contexts is also associated with the same one or more contexts. Parametric runtime constant pools **606a-b** and contexts have a one-to-many relationship: each parametric runtime constant pool relates to one or more contexts; each context relates to a single parametric runtime constant pool.

(116) In one or more embodiments, a parametric runtime constant pool stores resolution states for multiple co-dependent constants. A constant that depends on a parametric constant is also itself parametric. (Further descriptions regarding dependency are included below with reference to FIG. 13.)

(117) In one or more embodiments, a particular parametric constant corresponds to the same index in each of a set of parametric runtime constant pools **606a-b**. However, the respective entries at the same index in different parametric runtime constant pools **606a-b** point to different resolved values **614a-b** within a heap **608**.

(118) As illustrated, for example, a type defines four constants: Index #1: [a first invariant constant] Index #2: [a second invariant constant] Index #3: [a first parametric constant] Index #4: [a second parametric constant that depends on the first parametric constant]

(119) A per-type runtime constant pool **602a** includes an invariant runtime constant pool **604**. The invariant runtime constant pool **604** stores entries for Index #1 and Index #2. Index #1 points to resolved value **610** within a heap **608**. The resolved value **610** referenced by Index #1 is the resolved value for the first invariant constant corresponding to Index #1.

(120) The per-type runtime constant pool **602a** includes a parametric runtime constant pool **606a**, associated with one context, and another parametric runtime constant pool **606b**, associated with another context.

(121) The parametric runtime constant pool **606a** stores entries for Index #3 and Index #4. Index #3 points to resolved value **614a** within the heap **608**. The resolved value **614a** referenced by Index #3 is the resolved value for the first parametric constant corresponding to Index #3. Further, the resolved value **614a** is the resolved value for the first parametric constant within the context associated with the parametric runtime constant pool **606a**.

(122) The parametric runtime constant pool **606b** also stores entries for Index #3 and Index #4. The resolved value **614b** referenced by Index #3 is the resolved value for the first parametric constant

corresponding to Index #3. Further, the resolved value **614b** is the resolved value for the first parametric constant within the context associated with the parametric runtime constant pool **606b**. Resolved values **614a-b** may be same or different.

(123) FIG. 7 illustrates a call stack storing information for constants, including parametric constants, according to an embodiment.

(124) In one or more embodiments, a call stack **700** includes stack frames **702a-d**. A stack frame (such as stack frame **702b**, **702d**) may correspond to execution of an application programming interface (API) point that depends on a parametric constant. A caller to the API point supplies a context for the execution of the API point. The contextual information is passed from a caller stack frame to a callee stack frame. The callee stack frame therefore is associated with the context supplied by the caller stack frame.

(125) In an example, a type Bicycle defines a first parametric constant and a first API point dependent on the first parametric constant. Another type Boat defines a second parametric constant and a second API point dependent on the second parametric constant.

(126) Stack frame **702a** corresponds to execution of a first caller method. The first caller method calls the first API point in Bicycle. The first caller method supplies a context **710a** for the execution of the first API point.

(127) Based on the call to the first API point, a new stack frame **702b** is pushed onto the call stack **700**. Stack frame **702a** corresponds to execution of the first API point. Information passed from stack frame **702a** to stack frame **702b** includes arguments to the first API point as well as the context **710a**. Context **710a** may be referred to as a “context” for stack frame **702b**. Execution of the first API point invokes a second caller method.

(128) Based on the call to the second caller method, a new stack frame **702c** is pushed onto the call stack **700**. Stack frame **702c** corresponds to execution of the second caller method. The second caller method calls the second API point in Boat. The second caller method supplies a context **710c** for the execution of the second API point.

(129) Based on the call to the second API point, a new stack frame **702d** is pushed onto the call stack **700**. Stack frame **702d** corresponds to execution of the second API point. Information passed from stack frame **702c** to stack frame **702d** includes arguments to the second API point as well as the context **710c**. Context **710c** may be referred to as a “context” for stack frame **702d**.

(130) In one or more embodiments, a per-type runtime constant pool is relevant to each stack frame. Potentially multiple per-type runtime constant pools may exist in a runtime environment, each corresponding to a respective type loaded in the runtime environment. A per-type runtime constant pool relevant to a particular stack frame corresponding to execution of a particular API point in a particular type is the per-type runtime constant pool corresponding to the particular type.

(131) In one or more embodiments, each stack frame **702a-d** is associated with a runtime constant pool reference pointing to the relevant per-type runtime constant pool. Where a stack frame **702b** corresponds to execution of an API point that depends on a parametric constant, the runtime constant pool reference includes an invariant runtime constant pool reference **706b** and a parametric runtime constant pool reference **708b**. The invariant runtime constant pool reference **706b** points to the invariant runtime constant pool of the type including the API point. The parametric runtime constant pool reference **708b** points to the parametric runtime constant pool that is (a) of the type including the API point and (b) associated with the same context as the stack frame **702b**.

(132) Referring to the above example, stack frame **702a** is associated with runtime constant pool reference **703a**; stack frame **702b** is associated with runtime constant pool reference **703b**; stack frame **702c** is associated with runtime constant pool reference **703c**; and stack frame **702d** is associated with runtime constant pool reference **703d**.

(133) Stack frame **702b** corresponds to execution of the first API point in Bicycle. Runtime constant pool reference **702b** includes invariant runtime constant pool reference **706b** and

parametric runtime constant pool reference **708b**. Invariant runtime constant pool reference **706b** points to the invariant runtime constant pool associated with the type Bicycle. Parametric runtime constant pool reference **708b** points to one of a set of parametric runtime constant pools associated with the type Bicycle. The referenced parametric runtime constant pool is associated with the same context **710a** as stack frame **702b**.

(134) Stack frame **702d** corresponds to execution of the second API point in Boat. Runtime constant pool reference **702d** includes invariant runtime constant pool reference **706d** and parametric runtime constant pool reference **708d**. Invariant runtime constant pool reference **706d** points to the invariant runtime constant pool associated with the type Boat. Parametric runtime constant pool reference **708d** points to one of a set of parametric runtime constant pools associated with the type Boat. The referenced parametric runtime constant pool is associated with the same context **710c** as stack frame **702d**.

(135) In one or more embodiments, operations executed within each stack frame **702a-d** rely on the stack frame's runtime constant pool reference to access relevant resolution states of relevant constants. Operations within a stack frame cannot access resolution states outside of the per-type runtime constant pool referenced by the stack frame's runtime constant pool reference.

(136) Referring to the above example, stack frame **702b** corresponds to execution of the first API point in Bicycle. The type Bicycle is associated with multiple parametric runtime constant pools, each storing entries for a same set of parametric constants. Stack frame **702b** includes a runtime constant pool reference **703b**, which includes invariant runtime constant pool reference **706b** and parametric runtime constant pool reference **708b**. Operations executed within stack frame **702b** may access resolution states within the parametric runtime constant pool referenced by parametric runtime constant pool reference **708b**; however, operations executed within stack frame **702b** cannot access resolution states within other parametric runtime constant pools associated with the same set of parametric constants.

(137) Stack frame **702d** corresponds to execution of the second API point in Boat. The type Boat is associated with multiple parametric runtime constant pools, each storing entries for a same set of parametric constants. Stack frame **702d** includes a runtime constant pool reference **703d**, which includes invariant runtime constant pool reference **706d** and parametric runtime constant pool reference **708d**. Operations executed within stack frame **702d** may access resolution states within the parametric runtime constant pool referenced by parametric runtime constant pool reference **708d**; however, operations executed within stack frame **702d** cannot access resolution states within other parametric runtime constant pools associated with the same set of parametric constants.

(138) In one or more embodiments, stack frames corresponding to different executions of one or more API points that are dependent on a same parametric constant within a same context reference a same parametric runtime constant pool. Accordingly, every execution of API points dependent on a same parametric constant within a same context references the same resolution state for the parametric constant. Further, the resolved value is unchangeable for the resolution state as described above. Therefore, the resolved value is constant and permanent for the parametric constant across different executions of the API points within the same context. Conversely, different executions of API points dependent on a same parametric constant in different contexts reference different resolution states for the parametric constant. Therefore, different executions in different contexts may access different resolved values for the different resolution states of the same parametric constant.

#### 4. PARAMETRIC APPLICATION PROGRAMMING INTERFACE (API) POINTS

(139) FIG. 8 illustrates a class file including one or more parametric API points according to an embodiment.

(140) In one or more embodiments, a class file **800** for a type includes various information structures for different components of the type, including a class structure **802**, one or more field structures **804**, and one or more method structures **806**. Further, a class file **800** includes a constant

pool table **832** and a bootstrap method table **838**. A class file **800** is similar to a class file **200** of FIG. 2. A class structure **802** is similar to a class structure **204** of FIG. 2. A field structure **804** is similar to a field structure **208** of FIG. 2. A method structure **806** is similar to a method structure **209** of FIG. 2. A constant pool table **832** is similar to a constant table **201** of FIG. 2.

(141) In one or more embodiments, an information structure for an application programming interface (API) point is associated with a descriptor. The term “API point” as used herein refers to an interface, a class, a field, a method, and/or a constructor. As illustrated, a field structure **804** for a field in the type is associated with a descriptor **812**; a method structure **806** for a method in the type is associated with a descriptor **822**.

(142) A descriptor for an API point indicates a name and type of the API point. As illustrated, descriptor **812** indicates name **814** and type **816** for field structure **804**; descriptor **822** indicates name **824** and type **826** for method structure **806**. A descriptor for a field indicates a name of the field and a type of the field. A type of a field may also be referred to specifically as a “field type.” A descriptor for a method indicates a name of the method, and one or more types of a method return value, and zero or more method parameters.

(143) In one or more embodiments, an information structure for an API point is associated with an attributes table. As illustrated, a class structure **802** for a type is associated with an attributes table **808**; a field structure **804** for a field in the type is associated with an attributes table **818**; a method structure **806** for a method in the type is associated with an attributes table **828**. An attributes table (such as any of attributes tables **808**, **818**, **828**) includes zero or more attributes associated with the corresponding API point.

(144) In one or more embodiments, a parametric attribute (such as any of parametric attributes **810**, **820**, **830**) is a kind of attribute that marks an API point as parametric and therefore specializable with respect to a particular context. If a parametric attribute is present in an information structure for an API point, then the API point is parametric. If no parametric attribute is present in an information structure for an API point, then the API point is invariant.

(145) A parametric attribute includes an attribute name index, an attribute length, and a parametric constant reference. The attribute name index indicates an identifier for the parametric attribute (such as the string, “Parametric”). The attribute length indicates a length of the subsequent information in the parametric attribute. The parametric constant reference points to a constant (for example, the parametric constant reference is an index into the constant pool table **832**) that is parametric. (The referenced parametric constant may be a specialization anchor constant, which is further discussed below with reference to specialization anchor constant **906** of FIG. 9.) Based on the reference from a parametric attribute, a dependency from the API point on the parametric constant is established. As illustrated, a parametric attribute **810** associated with a class structure **802** for a type references a parametric constant **834** within a constant pool table **832**, thereby indicating that the type depends on the parametric constant **834**. A parametric attribute **820** associated with a field structure **804** for a field in the type references the parametric constant **834** within the constant pool table **832**, thereby indicating that the field depends on the parametric constant **834**. A parametric attribute **830** associated with a method structure **806** for a method in the type references a parametric constant **836** within the constant pool table **832**, thereby indicating that the method depends on the parametric constant **836**.

(146) In one or more embodiments, a constant pool table **832** of a type includes a set of entries corresponding to respective constants (such as parametric constants **834-836**) defined by the type. Each entry is an information structure for a corresponding constant. An information structure for a constant includes a tag and an information array. The tag indicates a kind of the corresponding constant. The information array includes information about the corresponding constant. The information array may include, for example, a reference to a bootstrap method for the corresponding constant.

(147) In one or more embodiments, a bootstrap method (such as any of bootstrap methods **840-**

**842**) for a constant is a method configured to bring a constant from an unresolved state to a resolution state. A bootstrap method is configured to determine a resolved value (or an error) for a resolution state of a constant. As illustrated, for example, bootstrap method **840** corresponds to parametric constant **834**; bootstrap method **842** corresponds to parametric constant **836**.

(148) FIG. **9** illustrates information structures for a specialization anchor constant and a specialization linkage constant according to an embodiment.

(149) In one or more embodiments, a callee **902** defines (or inherits from a supertype) an API point **904**. Further the callee **902** defines a specialization anchor constant **906**. A class file for the callee **902** may, for example, include an information structure for the API point **904**, and an entry in a constant pool table for the specialization anchor constant **906**. The term “caller” as used herein may refer to a type or method including a call to an API point, or may refer to the API point itself. A “caller” and a “callee” may reside in a same type or different types.

(150) In one or more embodiments, a callee **902** specifies a dependency from an API point **904** on a specialization anchor constant **906**. The API point **904** may, for example, be associated with a parametric attribute that includes a parametric constant reference to the specialization anchor constant **906**. Though not illustrated, multiple API points defined by the callee **902** may depend on the same specialization anchor constant **906**. Additionally or alternatively, another API point defined by the callee **902** may depend on another specialization anchor constant defined by the callee **902**.

(151) In one or more embodiments, a specialization anchor constant **906** (also referred to herein as an “anchor constant”) is a parametric constant used to declare a distinct degree of freedom of parametricity for parametric API points defined by the type. An information structure for a specialization anchor constant **906** includes a tag, an anchor kind, and a bootstrap method reference. The tag indicates an identifier for the anchor constant. The anchor kind indicates a kind of parametricity associated with the anchor constant. The bootstrap method reference points to a bootstrap method **908** (for example, the bootstrap method reference is an index into a bootstrap method table in the callee **902**).

(152) In an embodiment, an anchor constant **906** may be associated with one of various kinds of parametricity. A “class parametricity” involves a degree of freedom that applies to a class as a whole. Additionally or alternatively, a “method parametricity” involves a degree of freedom that applies to a method. Each anchor constant of the “method parametricity” kind varies independently from other anchor constants in the same type. Additionally or alternatively, a “method and class parametricity” involves a degree of freedom that applies to a method. An anchor constant of the “method and class parametricity” kind, by definition, depends on another anchor constant of the “class parametricity” kind in the same type.

(153) In an embodiment, a bootstrap method **908** is configured to bring an anchor constant **906** from an unresolved state to a resolution state. A bootstrap method **908** returns different resolved values for different resolution states of an anchor constant **906** within different contexts.

(154) A bootstrap method **908** accepts as an argument a selector value **918** indicating a callee's **902** proposed specialization for the API point **904**. A bootstrap method **908** may include operations configured to verify whether the selector value **918** is valid for the anchor constant **906**. If the selector value **918** is valid, the bootstrap method **908** determines a set of specialization decisions for the API point **904** based on the selector value **918**. The bootstrap method returns a resolved value for a resolution state of the anchor constant **906**; the resolved value indicates the set of specialization decisions and may be referred to as an “anchor value,” which is further discussed below with reference to anchor value **1302** of FIG. **13**. However if the selector value **918** is not valid, the bootstrap method **908** returns an error for the resolution state of the anchor constant **906**.

(155) In one or more embodiments, a caller **910** defines a call site **912** and a specialization linkage constant **914**. A class file for the caller **910** may include, for example, an instruction that calls an API point **904** of a callee **902**. The class file for the caller **910** may further include an entry in a

constant pool table for the specialization linkage constant **914**. The term “callee” as used herein may refer to a type or method including an API point being called, or may refer to the API point itself. A “caller” and A “callee” may reside in a same type or different types.

(156) In one or more embodiments, a caller **910** specifies an operand of an instruction at a call site **912**. The operand may be either a reference to an API point **904** being called, or a specialization linkage constant **914**. Where the operand is a specialization linkage constant **914**, an association between the call site **912** and the specialization linkage constant **914** is established. Though not illustrated, multiple call sites defined by the caller **910** may be associated with the same specialization linkage constant **914**. Additionally or alternatively, another call site defined by the caller **910** may be associated with a different specialization linkage constant defined by the caller **910**.

(157) In one or more embodiments, a specialization linkage constant **914** (also referred to as a “linkage constant”) is a constant used to add parametric information to a call to an API point **904**. An information structure for a specialization linkage constant **914** includes a tag, an API point reference **916**, and a selector value **916** applicable to a call to the referenced API point **904**. The tag indicates an identifier for the linkage constant. The API point reference **916** points to the API point **904** being called (for example, the API point reference is an index into the constant pool table in the caller **910** that corresponds to the API point **904**, which may be referred to as a “symbolic reference” to the API point **904**). The selector value **916** indicates a context for the call to the API point **904**, as further described below.

(158) In one or more embodiments, a selector value **916** is another constant defined by the caller **910**. The selector value **916** may be previously validated by the callee **902**, or may be unvalidated. If the selector value **916** is previously validated, then the selector value **916** is an anchor value, determined as a resolved value for a resolution state of the anchor constant **906**. If the selector value **916** is unvalidated, then the selector value **916** includes information intended to request some specialization of the API point **904**. For example, a callee requesting creation of List<Point> may reference a selector value that references the class List and the class Point. An unvalidated selector value **916** is input as an argument into the bootstrap method **908** for resolving the anchor constant **906**.

(159) FIGS. **10A-10B** illustrate state machines for a specialization anchor constant and a specialization linkage constant according to an embodiment.

(160) In one or more embodiments, a specialization anchor constant **1002** may be associated with one or more state machines **1008**. A state machine **1008** for an anchor constant **1002** includes two states: an unresolved state **1004** and a resolution state **1006**. The anchor constant **1002** is first prepared and enters the unresolved state **1004**. The anchor constant **1002** is then resolved (for example, via execution of a bootstrap method) and enters the resolution state **1006**. Once in the resolution state **1006**, the anchor constant **1002** cannot assume any other states within the state machine **1008**. A resolved value determined for the resolution state **1006** is not changeable.

(161) In one or more embodiments, unless the resolution state **1006** indicates an error, the resolution state **1006** indicates a set of specialization decisions for the anchor constant **1002** within a particular context—the context associated with a selector value provided by a callee. The set of specialization decisions may be embodied in an “anchor value,” which is further discussed below with reference to anchor value **1302** of FIG. **13**. In an embodiment, an anchor constant **906** is a loadable constant. The loadable value of an anchor constant **906** includes at least a subset of information indicated by the anchor value.

(162) In one or more embodiments, an anchor constant **1002** is associated with (a) a state machine within a default context and (b) zero or more additional state machines within contexts supplied by callers to API points dependent on the anchor constant **1002**. Each additional state machine is associated with a call to a dependent API point within a new context. However, the state machine within the default context is associated with an initial preparation and resolution of a type defining

the anchor constant **1002**. Within the state machine within the default context, the resolution state for the anchor constant **1002** is referred to as a “default resolution state,” and the anchor value resolved for the anchor constant **1002** is referred to as a “default anchor value.”

(163) In one or more embodiments, a state machine **1018** for a specialization linkage constant **1012** includes two states: an unresolved state **1014** and a resolution state **1016**. The linkage constant **1012** is first prepared and enters the unresolved state **1014**. The linkage constant **1012** is then resolved and enters the resolution state **1016**. Once in the resolution state **1016**, the linkage constant **1012** cannot assume any other states within the state machine **1018**. A resolved value determined for the resolution state **1016** is not changeable.

(164) In one or more embodiments, unless the resolution state **1016** indicates an error, the resolution state **1016** indicates an API point and an anchor value determined for the anchor constant **1002** on which the API point depends. A resolved value for the resolution state **1016** includes a direct reference (rather than a symbolic reference) to the API point **904** and a direct reference to the anchor value. As described above, the anchor value embodies a set of specialization decisions by the callee based on a selector value provided by the caller.

(165) FIG. **11** illustrates storage of an anchor value included in resolved values for resolution states of a specialization anchor constant and a specialization linkage constant according to an embodiment.

(166) In one or more embodiments, runtime data areas **1100** of a virtual machine includes a per-type runtime constant pool **1102** associated with a callee, a per-type runtime constant pool **1104** associated with a caller, and a heap **1106**. In an alternative embodiment, the callee and the caller may reside in a common type, and therefore be associated with the same per-type runtime constant pool.

(167) In one or more embodiments, a callee defines an anchor constant. The anchor constant is within a constant pool table of the callee. The anchor constant occupies an entry in the callee's per-type constant pool **1102**. As illustrated, for example, an anchor constant occupies Index #3.

(168) In one or more embodiments, a resolved value for a resolution state of an anchor constant indicates an anchor value **1108**. Therefore, a resolution state of the anchor constant includes a reference to the anchor value **1108** stored within the heap **1106**.

(169) In one or more embodiments, a caller defines a linkage constant. The linkage constant is within a constant pool table of the caller. The linkage constant occupies an entry in the caller's per-type constant pool **1102**. As illustrated, for example, an linkage constant occupies Index #7.

(170) In one or more embodiments, a resolved value for a resolution state of an linkage constant indicates an anchor value **1108** (and an API point specialized based on the anchor value **1108**). Therefore, a resolution state of the linkage constant includes a reference to the anchor value **1108** stored within the heap **1106**. Hence, each of the anchor constant and the linkage constant is resolved to point to a same anchor value **1108**.

(171) FIG. **12A** illustrates an unspecialized type and a specialized type that is the unspecialized type specialized within a particular context according to an embodiment.

(172) In one or more embodiments, an unspecialized type (such as an unspecialized containing type **1202**, an unspecialized field type **1208**, an unspecialized method parameter type (not illustrated), and/or an unspecialized method return value type (not illustrated)) is associated with a class structure (such as class structure **204** of FIG. **2**). A class structure for an unspecialized type includes one or more of: a definition of a constant pool table corresponding to the unspecialized type; an identification of a superclass (a default value, such as zero, may indicate a default class, such as Object); identification(s) of one or more superinterfaces; a fields table; a methods table; and/or an attributes table.

(173) In an embodiment, each entry in a fields table is a field structure (such as field structure **208** of FIG. **2**). A field structure provides a complete description of a field (such as field **1206**) in the unspecialized type. A fields table includes fields declared by the unspecialized type; a fields table

does not necessarily include fields that are inherited from superclasses or superinterfaces.

(174) In an embodiment, a field structure for a field **1206** indicates a descriptor for the field **1206**. The descriptor indicates a name and unspecialized field type **1208** of the field.

(175) In an embodiment, a field **1206** is declared, in source code, as being parametrized over a type parameter T. During compilation into virtual machine instructions, the type parameter T is erased to become an upper bound type associated with the type parameter T. The upper bound type of the type parameter T is either specified in the source code, or assumed to be Object. The upper bound type of the type parameter T is used as the unspecialized field type **1208** of the field **1206**.

Therefore, the descriptor of the field **1206** indicates the upper bound type of the type parameter T as the unspecialized field type **1208** of the field **1206**.

(176) In an embodiment, each entry in a methods table is a method structure (such as method structure **209** of FIG. 2). A method structure provides a complete description of a method in the unspecialized type. A methods table includes methods declared by the unspecialized type; a methods table does not necessarily include methods that are inherited from superclasses or superinterfaces.

(177) In an embodiment, a method structure for a method indicates a descriptor for the method. The descriptor indicates a name of the method, unspecialized types of method parameters (if any), and an unspecialized type of a method return value (if any).

(178) In an embodiment, a method parameter and/or method return value of a method is declared, in source code, as being parametrized over a type parameter T. During compilation into virtual machine instructions, the type parameter T is erased to become an upper bound type associated with the type parameter T. The upper bound type of the type parameter T is either specified in the source code, or assumed to be Object. The upper bound type of the type parameter T is used as an unspecialized method parameter type and/or unspecialized method return value type associated with the method. Therefore, the descriptor of the method indicates the upper bound type of the type parameter T as the unspecialized method parameter type and/or unspecialized method return value type.

(179) In one or more embodiments, a specialized type (such as a specialized containing type **1214**, a specialized field type **1212**, a specialized method parameter type (not illustrated), and/or a specialized method return value type (not illustrated)) is an unspecialized type specialized within a particular context **1204**.

(180) As illustrated, for example, an unspecialized containing type **1202** defines a field **1206** and specifies that the field **1206** is of an unspecialized field type **1208**. In particular, the unspecialized containing type **1202** provides a descriptor corresponding to the field **1206** that indicates the unspecialized field type **1208** for the field **1206**. The unspecialized containing type **1202** may further define a method (not illustrated) associated with an unspecialized method parameter type and an unspecialized method return value type. In particular, the unspecialized containing type **1202** provides a descriptor corresponding to the method that indicates the unspecialized method parameter type and the unspecialized method return value type for the method.

(181) A caller may call the unspecialized containing type **1202**, the field **1208** in the unspecialized containing type **1202**, and/or the method in the unspecialized containing type **1202**. The caller may make the call within a particular context **1204**. The caller may specify the context **1204** by, for example, specifying an anchor value.

(182) The unspecialized containing type **1202** specialized within the particular context **1204** is a specialized containing type **1214**. The specialized containing type **1214** may be the unspecialized containing type **1202** called in conjunction with the anchor value. An object (or class mirror) represents the unspecialized containing type **1202**; a different object (or class mirror) represents the specialized containing type **1214**.

(183) Additionally or alternatively, the unspecialized field type **1208** specialized within the particular context **1204** is a specialized field type **1212**. The specialized field type **1212** is the

unspecialized field type **1208** adorned with one or more type restrictions **1210** indicated by the particular context **1204**. The type restrictions **1210** may be indicated by the anchor value. A type restriction **1210** prohibits the field **1206** from assuming one or more values that are valid for the unspecialized field type **1208**.

(184) Additionally or alternatively, the unspecialized method parameter type specialized within the particular context **1204** is a specialized method parameter type. The unspecialized method return value type specialized within the particular context **1204** is a specialized method return value type. The specialized method parameter type and/or method return value type is the unspecialized method parameter type and/or method return value type adorned with one or more type restrictions indicated by the particular context **1204**. The type restrictions may be indicated by the anchor value. A type restriction prohibits the method parameter and/or method return value from assuming one or more values that are valid for the unspecialized method parameter type and/or method return value type. A particular context **1204** may provide same or different type restrictions to fields, method parameters, and/or method return values in a same specialized containing type **1214**.

(185) Therefore, an unspecialized containing type **1202** “indicates” an unspecialized field type **1208** of a field **1206**; a specialized containing type **1214** “indicates” a specialized field type **1212** of the same field **1206**. Additionally or alternatively, a descriptor corresponding to a field **1206** “indicates” an unspecialized field type **1208** of the field **1206**; a context **1204** (which may be provided by an anchor value), together with the descriptor, “indicates” a specialized field type **1212** of the field **1206**.

(186) FIG. **12B** illustrates an object of a specialized type according to an embodiment.

(187) In one or more embodiments, a type (unspecialized or specialized) is associated with a memory layout. A memory layout defines a sequence of fields of the type, and a respective size of each field. Further, the type is associated with a memory size. The memory size includes a total size of all fields of the type.

(188) In one or more embodiments, an underlying unspecialized type defines (or inherits) fields **1226a-c**. A specialized type results from the underlying unspecialized type specialized based on an anchor value **1230**. In an embodiment, a memory layout **1234** for the specialized type may be same as or different from an underlying unspecialized type. In particular, sizes of fields **1226a-c** may be modified based on one or more type restrictions, or other information, indicated by the anchor value **1230**. Additionally or alternatively, a sequence of fields **1226a-c** may be modified based on one or more type restrictions, or other information, indicated by the anchor value **1230**. Given a modified memory layout **1234**, the specialized type may be associated with a different memory size than the underlying unspecialized type.

(189) In one or more embodiments, an object of a specialized type is stored in accordance with a memory layout and/or memory size associated with the specialized type. As illustrated, for example, an object of a specialized type occupies a memory space **1224** within a heap **1222**. The object is associated with a memory layout **1234** of the specialized type. The memory layout **1234** provides how fields **1226a-c** are stored within the memory space **1224**. The object is associated with a memory size of the specialized type.

(190) In one or more embodiments, an object of a specialized type is stored in association with the specialized type. As illustrated, for example, an object of a specialized type is associated with metadata **1228**. The metadata **1228** may be stored, for example, in a header of the object. The metadata **1228** indicates an anchor value **1230** providing specialization for the specialized type. The metadata **1228** indicates a recorded specialized type **1232** for the object. The recorded specialized type **1232** is the specialized type of the object, as recorded in association with the object. The recorded specialized type **1232** may be indicated, for example, using a reference to an object (such as a class mirror) representing the specialized type.

(191) FIG. **13** illustrates a resolved value, namely an anchor value, for a resolution state of a specialization anchor constant according to an embodiment.

(192) In one or more embodiments, an anchor value **1302** stores a set of specialization decisions for an API point defined by a caller based on a selector value provided by a callee. An anchor value **1302** is an object stored on a heap. An anchor value **1302** is an object of a particular type, which may be referred to as “specialization anchor.” The “specialization anchor” type may define one or more fields indicating the following information: anchor constant **1304**, selector value **1306**, dependent constant **1307**, memory layout **1308**, memory size **1310**, object (such as a class mirror) **1312** representing a specialized class, type restriction **1314**, and/or associated default anchor value **1316**.

(193) In one or more embodiments, an anchor value **1302** stores a reference to an anchor constant **1304** bound to the anchor value **1302**. The reference points to the anchor constant **1304** within the runtime constant pool of the type that defines the anchor constant **1304**.

(194) In one or more embodiments, an anchor value **1302** stores reference(s) to one or more relevant selector values **1306**. A particular selector value **1306** is relevant to an anchor value **1302** if an anchor constant **1304** is resolved to the anchor value **1302** based on the particular selector value **1306**.

(195) In one or more embodiments, an anchor value **1302** stores reference(s) to one or more dependent constants **1307**. In an embodiment, a constant A is referred to as being “dependent” on another constant B if and only if at least one of the following circumstances is true: A contains an index referring to B; A contains an index referring to a bootstrap method in the type that defines A, and one of the static arguments of the bootstrap method refers to B; A is an anchor constant of the “method and class parametricity” kind and B is the corresponding anchor constant of the “class parametricity” kind.

(196) When an anchor value **1302** is determined, the dependent constants **1307** are prepared but not necessarily resolved. Each dependent constant **1307** may be independently resolved upon initial use.

(197) In one or more embodiments, an anchor value **1302** stores a memory layout **1308** for a specialized type resulting from specializing an underlying unspecialized type based on the anchor value **1302**. As an example, a memory layout **1308** for a specialized type may indicate that a field is of a particular size, whereas a memory layout for the underlying unspecialized type may indicate that the field is of a different size. As another example, a memory layout **1308** for a specialized type may indicate that a field is inlined, whereas a memory layout for the underlying unspecialized type may indicate that the field is referenced.

(198) In an embodiment, a memory layout **1308** for a specialized type may be determined based on one or more type restrictions **1314** applicable to one or more API points in the specialized type. The memory layout **1308** and the associated type restrictions **1314** may be indicated in the same anchor value **1302**.

(199) In one or more embodiments, an anchor value **1302** stores a memory size **1310** for a specialized type resulting from specializing an underlying unspecialized type based on the anchor value **1302**. The memory size **1310** may be determined based on adding the respective memory sizes of the fields in the specialized type, as provided by the memory layout **1308**.

(200) In one or more embodiments, an anchor value **1302** stores a reference to an object (such as a class mirror) representing a specialized type resulting from specializing an underlying unspecialized type based on the anchor value **1302**.

(201) In one or more embodiments, an anchor value **1302** stores one or more type restrictions applicable to one or more API points that are co-dependent on the anchor constant **1304**. A type restriction prohibits an API point from assuming a value that is valid for an unspecialized type of the API point. The unspecialized type of the API point adorned with the type restriction is a specialized type of the API point.

(202) In one or more embodiments, an anchor value **1302** stores a reference to an associated default anchor value **1316**. As described above, a default anchor value is resolved for an anchor constant

during an initial preparation and resolution of a type defining the anchor constant. A default anchor value for a particular anchor constant is referred to as being “associated” with an anchor value **1302** (determined in a different context) for the same particular anchor constant.

(203) FIG. **14** illustrates encapsulation of specialization decisions via restrictions on loadable values of specialization linkage constants according to an embodiment.

(204) In one or more embodiments, a linkage constant **1402** wraps around an API point that is a method, field, or constructor **1404**. A resolved value **1402** for the linkage constant **1402** indicates (a) the method, field, or constructor **1404** and (b) an anchor value **1406** specializing the method, field, or constructor **1404**. While the linkage constant **1402** is defined by the caller to the API point, the linkage constant **1402** has no loadable value **1408**. Therefore, the anchor value **1406** is not accessible to the caller.

(205) In one or more embodiments, a linkage constant **1412** wraps around an API point that is a class or interface **1414**. A resolved value **1412** for the linkage constant **1412** indicates (a) the class or interface **1414** and (b) an anchor value **1416** specializing the class or interface **1414**. While the linkage constant **1412** is defined by the caller to the API point, a loadable value **1418** of the linkage constant **1402** includes an object representing the specialized class **1420**, as indicated by the anchor value **1416**; the loadable value **1418** does not include other information provided by the anchor value **1416**. Therefore, the full value of the anchor value **1406** is not accessible to the caller.

(206) FIG. **15** illustrates a call to a parametric API point according to an embodiment.

(207) In one or more embodiments, a bytecode **1500** includes an instruction **1502** and an operand **1504**.

(208) In one or more embodiments, an instruction **1502** is associated with a command **1511** and an instruction type **1512**. A command **1511** provides an action to be executed (such as invoking a method, creating an object, accessing a field, and/or accessing a local variable). An instruction type **1512** provides a type of an operand **1504** (such as int, double, reference) to be operated upon using the command **1511**.

(209) In an embodiment, an instruction type **1512** of an instruction **1502** is determined based on a context **1510** associated with the instruction **1502**. In particular an instruction type **1512** may be narrowed based on a type restriction applicable within the context **1510**. A compiler may translate a source code instruction to a virtual machine instruction of a narrower instruction type based on a type restriction; additionally or alternatively, an interpreter may translate a virtual machine instruction to a machine code instruction of a narrower instruction type based on a type restriction. As an example, an unspecialized field type of a particular field may be Object. An instruction operating on the particular field without specialization may be of an instruction type associated with reference, such as *aload*. A specialized containing type may adorn the unspecialized field type with a type restriction, restricting the particular field to values of int. The specialized containing type may be associated with a memory layout that inlines the int value for the particular field within an instance of the specialized type. Hence, an instruction operating on the particular field may treat the particular field as having a specialized field type of int. The instruction may be of an instruction type associated with int, such as *iload*.

(210) In one or more embodiments, an operand **1504** may be an API point **708**, a linkage constant **1506**, and/or another data structure. Where the operand **1504** is a linkage constant **1506**, the operand **1504** adds parametric information to the API point **1508** that is wrapped by the linkage constant **1506** and being called. The linkage constant **1506** further supplies a context **1510** for the call to the API point **1508**. The context **1510** may indicate one or more type restrictions to be applied to a type, field, method parameter, and/or method return value.

(211) In an embodiment, a context **1510** within which a same resolution state of an anchor constant is accessed may be defined by a selector value and/or an anchor value. Where the linkage constant **1506** is not resolved, a context **1510** is provided as a selector value. Every access to an anchor constant using a same selector value accesses the same resolution state for the anchor constant. (An

access to the anchor constant using a different selector value may access a different resolution state for the anchor constant.) Where the linkage constant **1506** is resolved, a context **1510** is provided as a selector value and/or an anchor value. Every access to an anchor constant using a same anchor value accesses the same resolution state for the anchor constant. (An access to the anchor constant using a different anchor value may access a different resolution state for the anchor constant.)

## 5. RESOLVING A SPECIALIZATION ANCHOR CONSTANT AND A SPECIALIZATION LINKAGE CONSTANT

(212) One or more operations illustrated in FIGS. **16-19** may be modified, rearranged, or omitted all together. Accordingly, the particular sequence of operations illustrated in FIGS. **16-19** should not be construed as limiting the scope of one or more embodiments.

(213) FIG. **16** illustrates an example set of operations for preparing and resolving a type in a runtime environment, including preparing and resolving a parametric constant within a default context, according to an embodiment. The operations of FIG. **16** may be performed within a linking stage. Linking a type in a runtime environment involves verifying and preparing the type, the type's direct superclass, the type's direct superinterfaces, and the type's element type (if the type is an array type), if necessary. Linking also involves resolution of symbolic references in the type, though not necessarily at the same time as the type is verified and prepared. Further examples relating to linking be found in the Java® Virtual Machine Specification, Java SE 16 Edition, published Feb. 12, 2021, available at

<https://docs.oracle.com/javase/specs/jvms/se16/html/index.html>, which is hereby incorporated by reference in full.

(214) One or more embodiments include verifying a type that depends on an anchor constant (Operation **1604**). Verification ensures that the binary representation of a type is structurally correct. Verification may cause additional types to be loaded but need not cause the additional types to be verified or prepared.

(215) One or more embodiments include preparing the type (Operation **1606**). Preparation involves creating the static fields for the type. Preparing further involves initializing the static fields to the static field's default values. Preparation does not necessarily require the execution of any virtual machine code; explicit initializers for static fields may be executed as part of initialization, not preparation. During preparation of the type, loading constraints may be imposed. Preparation of the type may occur at any time following creation of the type but is completed prior to initialization of the type.

(216) In one or more embodiments, preparing the type includes preparing the anchor constant (Operation **1608**). Preparing the anchor constant includes allocating memory space for a default resolution state of the anchor constant (Operation **1610**). The virtual machine allocates a memory space in heap for storing a (default) resolved value for the default resolution state of the anchor constant. The size of the memory space allocated is determined based on a size associated with a type of the resolved value for the anchor constant. In an embodiment, the resolved value is an anchor value, which is an object of a “specialization anchor” type. Therefore, a memory space of a memory size associated with the “specialization anchor” type is allocated.

(217) One or more embodiments include resolving the type (Operation **1612**). Many virtual machine instructions rely on symbolic references in a runtime constant pool. The symbolic reference may be to, for example, (i) a class or interface, (ii) a field, (iii) a method, (iv) a method type, (v) a method handle, or (vi) a dynamically-computed constant. Initially, all symbolic references in the runtime constant pool are unresolved. Execution of instructions relying on a symbolic reference requires resolution of the symbolic reference. Resolution is the process of dynamically determining one or more concrete values from a symbolic reference in the runtime constant pool. If a resolution succeeds, subsequent attempts to resolve the symbolic reference succeed trivially and result in the same entity produced by the initial resolution. If the symbolic reference is to a dynamically-computed constant, the bootstrap method is not necessarily re-

executed for the subsequent attempts. If the resolution does not succeed, subsequent attempts to resolve the symbolic reference fail with the same error that was thrown as a result of the initial resolution attempt. If the symbolic reference is to a dynamically-computed constant, the bootstrap method is not necessarily re-executed for the subsequent attempts.

(218) In one or more embodiments, resolving the type includes resolving the anchor constant within a default context (Operation **1614**). Resolving the anchor constant within the default context includes obtaining a default resolved value (or error) within the default context (Operation **1616**). The default context applies where a caller attempts to use the anchor constant (for example, in association with an API point or constant that depends on the anchor constant) without supplying an explicit context. If the anchor constant is successfully resolved within the default context, then a default resolved value is determined. The default resolved value is a default anchor value for the anchor constant. The default anchor value may apply no modifications to an unspecialized type of the API point. For example, the default anchor value may indicate a memory layout and/or memory size that is same as the unspecialized type of the API point; the default anchor value may impose no type restrictions on the API point. If the anchor constant is not successfully resolved within the default context, then an error within the default context is determined. Further examples relating to obtaining a resolved value (or error) within a particular context are described below with reference to FIG. **19**.

(219) In an embodiment, the resolution of the anchor constant within the default context is performed during a resolution of the type defining the anchor constant. Therefore, the resolution process may be performed via executing a method defined by the runtime environment, rather than a bootstrap method corresponding to the anchor constant.

(220) One or more embodiments include storing the default resolved value as a permanent value for the default resolution state of the anchor constant (Operation **1616**). If the anchor constant is successfully resolved within the default context, then the default resolved value is stored as a permanent value for the default resolution state of the anchor constant. If the anchor constant is not successfully resolved within the default context, then the error within the default context is stored as a permanent value for the default resolution state of the anchor constant.

(221) FIG. **17** illustrates an example set of operations for executing a parametric API point within a particular context, including selecting a resolution state of a parametric constant associated with the particular context, according to an embodiment.

(222) One or more embodiments include receiving a call to an API point that depends on an anchor constant (Operation **1702**). A callee receives a call to an API point that depends on an anchor constant. The API point is defined in the callee, or the API point is defined in a supertype of the callee and inherited by the callee. The anchor constant is defined in the callee, such as being defined within a constant pool table of the callee.

(223) One or more embodiments include determining whether the call is associated with a linkage constant providing a particular context for execution of the API point (Operation **1704**). The callee determines whether the call is associated with a linkage constant providing a particular context for execution of the API point. Where a call is associated with a linkage constant, the linkage constant is passed from a call stack associated with the caller to a call stack associated with the callee. Therefore, the call is associated with a linkage constant if the linkage constant is accessible within the call stack associated with the callee.

(224) If the call is not associated with a linkage constant, one or more embodiments include selecting a default resolution state of the anchor constant (Operation **1716**). The callee selects a default resolution state of the anchor constant. The default resolution state may be determined during a linking stage of a type defining the anchor constant, as described above with reference to FIG. **16**.

(225) If the call is associated with a linkage constant, one or more embodiments include determining whether the particular context matches any existing contexts associated with resolution

states of the anchor constant (Operation **1718**). Different resolution states of the anchor constant are associated with different contexts. The callee determines whether the particular context provided by the call matches any existing contexts associated with resolution states of the anchor constant.

(226) If the particular context is provided as an unresolved linkage constant, and the unresolved linkage constant is not associated with a selector value that equals any anchor value previously resolved for the anchor constant, then the callee determines that particular context does not match any existing contexts associated with resolution states of the anchor constant.

(227) If the particular context is provided as an unresolved linkage constant, and the unresolved linkage constant is associated with a selector value that equals a particular anchor value previously resolved for the anchor constant, then the callee determines that particular context matches a context associated with the particular anchor value.

(228) If the particular context is provided as a resolved linkage constant, and the resolved linkage constant is associated with a particular anchor value previously resolved for the anchor constant, then the callee determines that particular context matches a context associated with the particular anchor value.

(229) If the particular context matches an existing context associated with a particular resolution state of the anchor constant, one or more embodiments include selecting the resolution state associated with the matching context (Operation **1718**). The callee selects the resolution state, for the anchor constant, associated with the matching context. A resolved value for the resolution state associated with the matching context thereby provides a specialization for the API point.

(230) Hence, if (a) the particular context is provided as an unresolved linkage constant, and the unresolved linkage constant is associated with a selector value that equals a particular anchor value previously resolved for the anchor constant, or (b) the particular context is provided as a resolved linkage constant, and the resolved linkage constant is associated with a particular anchor value previously resolved for the anchor constant, then the callee selects the resolution state associated with the particular anchor value.

(231) If the particular context does not match any existing context associated with resolution states of the anchor constant, one or more embodiments include resolving the linkage constant (Operation **1708**).

(232) In one or more embodiments, resolving the linkage constant includes resolving the API point, if not yet resolved (Operation **1710**). An unresolved linkage constant initially includes a symbolic reference to an API point to be called. The symbolic reference is resolved to a direct reference to the API point.

(233) In one or more embodiments, resolving the linkage constant includes preparing and resolving the anchor constant within the particular context (Operation **1712**). Further examples relating to preparing and resolving an anchor constant within a particular context are described below with reference to FIG. **18**.

(234) One or more embodiments include selecting the newly determined resolution state of the anchor constant (Operation **1714**). The callee selects the newly determined resolution state of the anchor constant. A resolved value for the newly determined resolution state thereby provides a specialization for the API point.

(235) One or more embodiments include executing the API point using the selected resolution state of the anchor constant (Operation **1720**). The callee executes the API point using the selected resolution state of the anchor constant. Further examples relating to executing an API point using a particular resolution state of an anchor constant are described below with reference to FIGS. **20-22**.

(236) One or more embodiments include executing the operations of FIG. **17** with respect to each call to an API point that depends on the same anchor constant. Different calls to the same API point that depends on the anchor constant trigger execution of the operations of FIG. **17**, wherein different resolution states of the same anchor constant may be selected based on Operations **1714-**

**1718.** Additionally or alternatively, different calls to different API points that depend on the same anchor constant trigger execution of the operations of FIG. 17, wherein different resolution states of the same anchor constant may be selected based on Operations **1714-1718**.

(237) FIG. 18 illustrates an example set of operations for preparing and resolving a parametric constant within particular contexts provided by calls to parametric API points dependent on the parametric constant according to an embodiment.

(238) One or more embodiments include receiving a request to prepare and resolve an anchor constant within a particular context (Operation **1802**). A caller makes a call to an API point that depends on an anchor constant. The call is made within a particular context. As an example, a call to an API point is made using an instruction and an operand. The operand is a linkage constant. The linkage constant is unresolved. An information structure for the linkage constant indicates a selector value. The selector value thereby provides a particular context for the call to the API point.

(239) Responsive to the call to the API point, a stack frame associated with the callee is pushed onto a call stack. The stack frame associated with the callee corresponds to execution of the API point responsive to the call made by the caller. Information representing the API point, such as direct reference to the API point, is passed from the stack frame associated with the caller to the stack frame associated with the callee. Further information representing the particular context, such as a selector value and/or an anchor value, is passed from the stack frame associated with the caller to the stack frame associated with the callee. The callee determines whether the API point is associated with a parametric attribute. The callee identifies an anchor constant referenced by the parametric attribute of the API point. The callee thereby receives a request to prepare and resolve the anchor constant within the particular context.

(240) One or more embodiments include preparing the anchor constant within the particular context (Operation **1804**). Preparing the anchor constant within the particular context includes generating or identifying a parametric runtime constant pool corresponding to the particular context (Operation **1806**). The callee identifies a set of zero or more parametric runtime constant pools associated with a type defining (or inheriting) the API point being called. The callee determines whether the particular context matches any context associated with the existing set of parametric runtime constant pools. The callee identifies the parametric runtime constant pool associated with the matching context. Otherwise, the callee generates a new parametric runtime constant pool associated with the particular context.

(241) Preparing the anchor constant within the particular context includes allocating a memory space, of the identified parametric runtime constant pool, for a new resolution state of the anchor constant (Operation **1808**). The callee allocates a memory space for a new resolution state of the anchor constant. The identified memory space is within the parametric runtime constant pool generated or identified at Operation **1806**. Examples of operations relating to allocating memory space for a resolution state of an anchor constant are further described above with reference to Operation **1610** of FIG. 16.

(242) One or more embodiments include resolving the anchor constant within the particular context (Operation **1810**). Resolving the anchor constant within the particular context includes executing a bootstrap method associated with the anchor constant to obtain a resolved value (or error) within the particular context (Operation **1812**). The callee identifies an information structure for the anchor constant. The information structure for the anchor constant references a bootstrap method corresponding to the anchor constant. The callee inputs information indicating the particular context into the bootstrap method.

(243) If the anchor constant is successfully resolved within the particular context, then a resolved value within the particular context is determined. The resolved value is an anchor value for the anchor constant within the particular context. The anchor value records a set of specialization decisions for the API point within the particular context. If the anchor constant is not successfully resolved within the particular context, then an error within the particular context is determined.

Further examples relating to obtaining a resolved value (or error) within a particular context are described below with reference to FIG. **19**.

(244) In an embodiment, resolution of the anchor constant within a particular context provided by a caller may be performed via executing a bootstrap method corresponding to the anchor constant. Different calls to one or more API points dependent on the same anchor constant may be made within different contexts. Each call within a different context triggers execution of the same bootstrap method corresponding to the anchor constant. However, each execution of the bootstrap method involves the input of different contexts, such as via different selector values.

(245) One or more embodiments include storing the resolved value as a permanent value for the resolution state of the anchor constant within the particular context (Operation **1814**). If the anchor constant is successfully resolved within the particular context, then the resolved value is stored as a permanent value for the resolution state of the anchor constant within the particular context. If the anchor constant is not successfully resolved within the particular context, then the error within the particular context is stored as a permanent value for the resolution state of the anchor constant within the particular context.

(246) FIG. **19** illustrates an example set of operations for determining an anchor value for a resolution state of an anchor constant according to an embodiment.

(247) One or more embodiments include receiving a request to obtain an anchor value for an anchor constant within a context of a proposed selector value (or a default context) (Operation **1902**). A callee receives a request to obtain an anchor value for an anchor constant within a context of a proposed selector value. The proposed selector value indicates a caller's proposed specializations for an API point dependent on the anchor constant. If no explicit context is supplied by a caller, then a default context serves as the context in which the anchor value is to be obtained.

(248) One or more embodiments include determining whether the proposed selector value valid with respect to the anchor constant (Operation **1904**). The callee executes a bootstrap method corresponding to the anchor constant. The bootstrap method includes operations configured to determine whether the proposed selector value is valid. The proposed selector value is not valid if the proposed selector value cannot be used to generate an anchor value for the anchor constant.

(249) If the proposed selector value is not valid, one or more embodiments include generating an error (Operation **1906**). The callee generates an error. The error is recorded as a permanent value for a resolution state of the anchor constant within the context of the proposed selector value.

(250) One or more embodiments include determining one or more type restrictions (Operation **1908**). The callee determines one or more type restrictions associated with the API point. The callee stores information indicating the type restrictions within the anchor value.

(251) As an example, a Box class may declare a field named point and parameterized over a parameter type T. During compilation, the parameter type T is erased to an unspecialized type Object. Hence, a class file for Box indicates that the field point is of an unspecialized type Object. The class file for Box further indicates that the field point is dependent on an anchor constant. A caller to the field point may propose to specialize the type of point to int. The Box class may execute a bootstrap method corresponding to the anchor constant. Execution of operations of the bootstrap method may determine that a type restriction is to be applied on the field point within the context provided by the caller's specialization proposal. The type restriction may restrict the value of the field point to values conforming to the int type.

(252) One or more embodiments include determining a memory layout (Operation **1910**). The callee determines a memory layout associated with a specialized type of the API point. The memory layout may be determined based on (a) the fields in the unspecialized type, and (b) one or more type restrictions, determined at Operation **1908**, on the fields in the unspecialized type. A type restriction may be used to optimize the memory layout for the specialized type, as compared with the unspecialized type. The memory layout for the specialized type includes an entry for each field that is in the unspecialized type (via direct definition by the unspecialized type or inheritance by the

unspecialized type)—even though the specialized type itself does not define the fields. The callee stores information indicating the memory layout within the anchor value.

(253) Continuing the above example, an int value may be associated with a size of 4 bytes; a reference value may be associated with a size of 8 bytes. The unspecialized type of Object associated with the field point provides that a value for the field stores a reference to an object. The reference is 8 bytes. The specialized type, which is the Object type restricted to values of int, associated with the field point provides that a value for the field stores an int value. The int value requires 4 bytes. Therefore, the callee may reduce a memory size allocated for the field point from 8 bytes to 4 bytes. The callee may further determine to inline the int value within an instance of the specialized type. The memory layout is therefore optimized based on the type restriction restricting to values of int.

(254) One or more embodiments include determining a memory size (Operation **1912**). The callee determines a memory size associated with a specialized type of the API point. The memory size may be determined based on a memory layout determined at Operation **1910**. The callee stores information indicating the memory size within the anchor value.

(255) Continuing the above example, a memory size for the field point has been reduced from 8 bytes to 4 bytes. Accordingly, the callee determines that an overall memory size associated with the specialized type Box<Int> is 4 bytes less than an overall memory size associated with the unspecialized type Box.

(256) One or more embodiments include generating an object representing a specialized type (Operation **1914**). The callee generates an object (such as a class mirror) representing the specialized type resulting from the unspecialized type of the API point specialized within the context of the proposed selector value. The callee stores a reference to the object representing the specialized type within the anchor value.

(257) One or more embodiments include identifying the associated anchor constant, selector value, and default anchor value (Operation **1916**). The callee identifies an anchor constant associated with the anchor value—that is, the anchor constant on which the API point being called depends. The callee identifies the selector value associated with the anchor value—that is, the selector value serving as an input to a bootstrap method of the anchor constant that obtains the anchor value. The callee identifies the default anchor value associated with the anchor value—that is, the anchor value determined in the default context for the same anchor constant. The callee stores references to the associated anchor constant, selector value, and default anchor value within the anchor value.

(258) One or more embodiments include returning the anchor value obtained within the context of the proposed selector value (Operation **1918**). The callee returns the anchor value obtained within the context of the proposed selector value.

## 6. EXECUTING PARAMETRIC API POINTS WITHIN PARTICULAR CONTEXTS

(259) One or more operations illustrated in FIGS. **20-22** may be modified, rearranged, or omitted all together. Accordingly, the particular sequence of operations illustrated in FIGS. **20-22** should not be construed as limiting the scope of one or more embodiments.

(260) FIG. **20** illustrates an example set of operations for executing an invocation instruction to invoke a parametric method according to an embodiment.

(261) One or more embodiments include identifying an invocation instruction to invoke a parametric callee method within a particular context (or a default context) (Operation **2002**). A caller provides an invocation instruction and one or more operands. The one or more operands indicate (a) a callee method to be invoked and (b) a particular context within which to invoke the callee method. In the embodiment, an operand associated with the invocation instruction is a linkage constant. A resolved value for the linkage constant includes a reference to the callee method, and a reference to an anchor value associated with the particular context.

(262) In an embodiment, operands of the invocation instruction do not explicitly provide any context. If no context is explicitly provided, then a default context applies.

- (263) One or more embodiments include pushing a stack frame, onto a call stack, corresponding to execution of the callee method responsive to the invocation instruction (Operation **2004**). A stack frame corresponding to execution of the callee method responsive to the invocation instruction is pushed onto the call stack. The stack frame corresponding to execution of the callee method is now the active frame.
- (264) One or more embodiments include passing the particular context to the active stack frame (Operation **2006**). Information indicating the particular context within which the callee method is to be invoked is passed from the stack frame associated with the caller to the stack frame associated with the callee. The information indicating the particular context may be, for example, an anchor value.
- (265) One or more embodiments include storing a constant pool reference, corresponding to the active stack frame, that indicates an invariant runtime constant pool and a parametric runtime constant pool associated with the particular context (Operation **2008**). A virtual machine determines that the particular context for invoking the callee method has been provided to the active frame. The virtual machine determines whether the callee method is associated with an anchor constant. The virtual machine determines, for example, whether the callee method is associated with a parametric attribute that references an anchor constant. If the callee method is associated with an anchor constant, then the callee method is a “parametric callee method.” The virtual machine identifies a set of one or more parametric runtime constant pools that (a) are associated with a type that defines (or inherits) the callee method and (b) store resolution states of the anchor constant. The virtual machine identifies a respective context associated with each of the set of parametric runtime constant pools. The virtual machine compares the particular context provided by the caller and the contexts associated with the set of parametric runtime constant pools to find a match. The virtual machine identifies one of the set of parametric runtime constant pools associated with a context matching the particular context. The virtual machine also identifies an invariant runtime constant pool associated with the type that defines (or inherits) the callee method.
- (266) The virtual machine stores as a constant pool reference, corresponding to the active stack frame, information indicating the identified invariant runtime constant pool and the identified parametric runtime constant pool associated with the particular context.
- (267) One or more embodiments include passing zero or more arguments to the active stack frame (Operation **2010**). If the callee method is not associated with any method parameters, no arguments are passed to the active stack. Otherwise, one or more arguments are passed from the stack frame associated with the caller to the stack frame associated with the callee.
- (268) In an embodiment, passing the argument includes determining whether the argument is to be inlined or referenced in the callee stack frame, and determining a memory size to be allocated for the inlined value or the reference in the callee stack frame. The virtual machine determines whether the particular context for invoking the callee method is associated with a specialized type for any method parameter. As an example, an anchor value may specify a type restriction on a method parameter. The type restriction may limit a memory size needed for the method parameter. Additionally or alternatively, the anchor value may specify whether the method parameter is to be inlined or referenced, and/or a memory size of the method parameter. Based on the specialized type of a method parameter within the particular context, the virtual machine determines whether the argument is to be inlined or referenced in the callee stack frame, and determines a memory size to be allocated for the inlined value or the reference in the callee stack frame. Based on the memory size to be allocated, the virtual machine allocates memory space for the argument as a local variable in the callee stack frame. Also based on the memory size to be allocated, the virtual machine allocates memory space for the argument on an operand stack of the callee frame.
- (269) One or more embodiments include executing the parametric callee method within the particular context (Operation **2011**). The virtual machine executes the parametric callee method within the particular context.

(270) One or more embodiments include accessing resolution states of one or more constants from the invariant runtime constant pool and/or parametric runtime constant pool (Operation **2012**). Executing the parametric callee method may include accessing resolution states of one or more constants defined by the type defining (or inheriting) the parametric callee method. The constants are accessed based on the constant pool reference of the active frame. Since the constant pool reference points to (a) the invariant runtime constant pool associated with the type and (b) the parametric runtime constant pool associated with the type and associated with the particular context, resolution states of invariant constants are accessed from the invariant runtime constant pool associated with the type, and resolution states of parametric constants (for example, the anchor constant and constants dependent on the anchor constant) are accessed from the parametric runtime constant pool associated with the type and associated with the particular context.

(271) One or more embodiments include identifying a type restriction applied to the method parameter and/or method return value within the particular context (Operation **2014**). The virtual machine identifies a type restriction applied to the method parameter and/or method return value within the particular context. The virtual machine identifies the anchor value associated with the particular context. The anchor value specifies any type restrictions applied to any method parameters and/or method return value of the callee method.

(272) One or more embodiments include type checking and/or casting an argument and/or method return value based on the type restriction (Operation **2016**). The virtual machine type checks an argument and/or method return value based on the type restriction. The virtual machine determines whether the argument for the callee method conforms to a type restriction. Additionally or alternatively, the virtual machine determines whether the method return value for the callee method conforms to a type restriction. As an example, an unspecialized type of a method parameter of a callee method is Object, and a type restriction restricts the method parameter to values of int. An argument to the callee method may be a String such as “hello.” The virtual machine type checks the argument based on the unspecialized type of the method parameter. The virtual machine determines that the “hello” String conforms to the Object type. Additionally the virtual machine type checks the argument based on the type restriction. The virtual machine determines that the “hello” String does not conform the int type. The virtual machine may determine that the argument does not pass type checking.

(273) If an argument and/or method return value does not pass type checking, the virtual machine may either generate an error, or cast the argument and/or method return value to conform to the type restriction. As an example, an unspecialized type of a method parameter of a callee method is Vehicle, and a type restriction restricts the method parameter to values of Bicycle. Bicycle is a sub-class of Vehicle, and adds a field gears. An argument to the callee method may be a Vehicle object. The virtual machine casts the Vehicle object to conform to the Bicycle type. In particular, the virtual machine may add the field gears and initialize the field to a default value. As used herein, the term “cast” may also include “convert.” As another example, an unspecialized type of a method parameter of a callee method is Vehicle, and a type restriction restricts the method parameter to values of int. int is not a sub-class of Vehicle. An argument to the callee method may be a Vehicle object. The virtual machine converts the Vehicle object to conform to the int type. In particular, the virtual machine may apply a conversion rule to the Vehicle object to convert the Vehicle object into an int value.

(274) Since different type restrictions may be applicable within different contexts, the same callee method executed within different contexts may involve type checking, converting, and/or casting based on different type restrictions. Whereas a certain argument to a callee method may conform with a type restriction within a particular context, the same argument to the same callee method may not conform with another type restriction within another context.

(275) One or more embodiments include determining whether to inline the argument and/or method return value based on the type restriction (Operation **2018**). The virtual machine determines

whether to inline the argument and/or method return value based on the type restriction. If the type restriction restricts the method parameter and/or method return value to a primitive type, then the virtual machine may determine to inline the argument and/or method return value.

(276) Since different type restrictions may be applicable within different contexts, a callee method executed within a particular context may involve inlining, while the same callee method executed within another context may involve using a reference.

(277) One or more embodiments include inlining the argument and/or method return value onto an operand stack corresponding to the active stack frame (Operation **2020**). The virtual machine inlines the argument and/or method return value onto an operand stack corresponding to the active stack frame. The virtual machine stores the data value of the argument and/or method return value directly onto the operand stack, rather than storing a reference to the argument and/or method return value.

(278) One or more embodiments include pushing a reference to the argument and/or method return value onto the operand stack (Operation **2022**). The virtual machine stores references to the argument and/or method return value onto the operand stack corresponding to the active stack frame.

(279) One or more embodiments include passing the method return value to the stack frame associated with the caller (Operation **2024**). The virtual machine passes the method return value to the caller stack frame. If the method return value is inlined, the virtual machine determines a memory size associated with the inlined data value. If the method return value is referenced, the virtual machine determines a memory size associated with the reference. The virtual machine allocates a memory space, based on the determined memory size, on an operand stack of the caller stack frame for the method return value. The virtual machine stores the method return value into the allocated memory space.

(280) FIG. **21** illustrates an example set of operations for executing a creation instruction to create an instance of a parametric type according to an embodiment.

(281) One or more embodiments include identifying a creation instruction to create an object based on an unspecialized type within a particular context (or a default context), wherein the object is of a specialized type that is the unspecialized type within the particular context (Operation **2102**). A caller provides a creation instruction and one or more operands. The one or more operands indicate (a) an unspecialized type and (b) a particular context applicable to the unspecialized type. The object to be created would be of a specialized type, which is the unspecialized type within the particular context. In an embodiment, an operand associated with the creation instruction is a linkage constant. A resolved value for the linkage constant includes a reference to the unspecialized type, and a reference to an anchor value associated with the particular context. The specialized type of the object to be created is the unspecialized type adorned with the anchor value. In an embodiment, the anchor value includes a reference to an object (such as a class mirror) representing the specialized type.

(282) In an embodiment, operands of the invocation instruction do not explicitly provide any context. If no context is explicitly provided, then a default context applies. The object to be created would be of a specialized type that is the unspecialized type within the default context. The specialized type of the object to be created is the unspecialized type adorned with a default anchor value.

(283) One or more embodiments include identifying a memory size and/or memory layout associated with the specialized type (Operation **2104**). The virtual machine identifies a memory size and/or memory layout associated with the specialized type. The anchor value specifies the memory size and/or memory layout associated with the specialized type.

(284) One or more embodiments include creating the object, including allocating memory space to the object based on the memory size and/or memory layout associated with the specialized type (Operation **2106**). The virtual machine allocates memory space to the object based on the memory

size and/or memory layout associated with the specialized type.

(285) Since different memory sizes and/or memory layouts are associated with different contexts, an object created based on an unspecialized type within different contexts involves allocating memory space of different memory sizes and/or memory layouts. As an example, one object created based on an unspecialized type within a particular context may have an inlined value for a particular field, while another object created based on the same unspecialized type but within another context may have a referenced value for the particular field.

(286) One or more embodiments include identifying an invocation instruction to invoke a constructor within the particular context (or in the default context) (Operation **2108**). The caller provides an invocation instruction and one or more operands. The one or more operands indicate (a) a constructor to be invoked, and (b) optionally the particular context within which to invoke the constructor. The constructor is defined by the unspecialized type (or by a supertype of the unspecialized type). The constructor may but does not necessarily depend on an anchor constant. The constructor may but does not necessarily depend on the same anchor constant on which the unspecialized type depends. If the constructor depends on an anchor constant, then the invocation instruction may supply the particular context for invoking the constructor. If the constructor depends on an anchor constant and the invocation instruction does not supply any context, then the default context is assumed.

(287) One or more embodiments include identifying the constructor defined (or inherited) by the unspecialized type (Operation **2110**). The virtual machines identified the constructor that is either defined by the unspecialized type, or defined by a supertype of the unspecialized type and inherited by the unspecialized type. A class file of the unspecialized type (or the supertype) includes an information structure for the constructor, specifying a descriptor for the constructor.

(288) One or more embodiments include identifying any type restrictions applied on a parameter and/or return value of the constructor within the particular context (Operation **2112**). The virtual machine executes the constructor. If the constructor depends on an anchor constant, the virtual machine executes the constructor within the particular context provided with the invocation instruction (or the default context, if none is provided). The virtual machine identifies any type restrictions applied on a parameter and/or return value of the constructor within the particular context. Examples of operations for identifying a type restriction on a parameter and/or return value are described above with reference to Operation **2014** of FIG. **20**.

(289) One or more embodiments include initializing the object, including executing the constructor within the particular context (Operation **2114**). Executing the constructor within the particular context includes type checking, casting, and/or inlining parameters and/or a return value based on type restrictions applicable within the particular context. Examples of operations relating to type checking, casting, and inlining are described above with reference to Operations **2016-2022** of FIG. **20**.

(290) One or more embodiments include storing, as metadata of the object, information indicating the specialized type of the object (Operation **2116**). The virtual machine stores, as metadata of the newly created object, information indicating the specialized type of the object. As an example, a header of an object includes a class reference indicating the object's class. The class reference of an object of a specialized type points to an object (such as a class mirror) representing the specialized type. A reference to the object representing the specialized type may be identified from the anchor value associated with the particular context.

(291) FIG. **22** illustrates an example set of operations for executing an access instruction to access a parametric field according to an embodiment.

(292) One or more embodiments include identifying an access instruction to access a parametric field of an object within a particular context (or a default context), wherein the object is expected to be of a particular specialized type that is an unspecialized type within the particular context (Operation **2202**). A caller provides an access instruction and one or more operands. The one or

more operands indicate (a) a field of an object and (b) a particular context within which to access the field. The particular context indicated by the operands, applied to some unspecialized type, results in a particular specialized type that is expected of the object. Accessing the field may include retrieving a data value from the field and/or storing a data value to the field. In an embodiment, an operand associated with the access instruction is a linkage constant. A resolved value for the linkage constant includes a reference to the field, and a reference to an anchor value associated with the particular context. The anchor value specifies a class reference to an object (such as a class mirror) representing the particular specialized type that is expected of the object. (293) In an embodiment, operands of the access instruction do not explicitly provide any context. If no context is explicitly provided, then a default context applies.

(294) One or more embodiments include identifying a recorded specialized type stored in association with the object (Operation **22**). The virtual machine identifies metadata of the object, such as a header of the object. The virtual machine identifies, within the metadata, a class reference. The class reference points to a specialized type of the object, which is referred to herein as a “recorded specialized type” of the object. Additionally or alternatively, the virtual machine identifies, within the metadata, a reference to an anchor value bound to the object. The anchor value includes a class reference that points to the recorded specialized type of the object.

(295) One or more embodiments include determining whether the particular specialized type matches the recorded specialized type (Operation **2206**). The virtual machine determines whether there is a match between (a) the particular specialized type associated with the particular context provided at Operation **2202** and (b) the recorded specialized type determined at Operation **2204**.

(296) If the particular specialized type matches the recorded specialized type, one or more embodiments include selecting the particular context for use (Operation **2214**). The virtual machine selects the particular context provided at Operation **2202** for use.

(297) If the particular specialized type does not match the recorded specialized type, one or more embodiments include determining whether a default context can be used (Operation **2208**). The virtual machine determines whether a default context can be used. The default context can be used if the field of the object can be accessed based on a memory layout for the unspecialized type.

(298) If the default context cannot be used, one or more embodiments include returning an error (Operation **2210**). The virtual machine returns an error.

(299) If the default context can be used, one or more embodiments include selecting the default context for use (Operation **2212**). The virtual machine selects the default context for use.

(300) One or more embodiments include accessing the field of the object within the selected context (Operation **2214**). The virtual machine accesses the field of the object within the selected context.

(301) One or more embodiments include identifying a type restriction applied to the field and/or memory layout associated with the object within the selected context (Operation **2218**). The virtual machine identifying a type restriction applied to the field and/or memory layout within the selected context. The virtual machine identifies an anchor value associated with the particular context, which may be (a) the anchor value provided with the access instruction at Operation **2202**, and/or (b) the anchor value recorded in association with the object and identified at Operation **2204**. The anchor value specifies any type restrictions applied to the field. The anchor value specifies a memory layout for the particular specialized type of the object.

(302) One or more embodiments include type checking and/or casting a value for the field of the object based on the type restriction applied to the field within the selected context (Operation **2220**). Examples of operations relating to type checking and/or casting a value are described above with reference to Operation **2016** of FIG. **20**.

(303) One or more embodiments include identifying a memory space for the field of the object based on the memory layout within the selected context (Operation **2222**). The virtual machine identifies a memory space for the field of the object based on the memory layout within the

selected context. As an example, a memory layout may indicate a sequence of fields of a specialized type, such as name, age, address. The memory layout may indicate a type and/or size of each field. The name field may take 8 bytes; the age field may take 4 bytes; the address field may take 8 bytes. Hence, the name field may correspond to an index of 0; the age field may correspond to an index of 8 (index of 0 plus 8 bytes of the name field); the address field may correspond to an index of 12 (index of 8 plus 4 bytes of the age field). A virtual machine may access a field by calculating the index corresponding to the field based on the memory layout.

(304) One or more embodiments include determining whether to inline the value for the field based on the type restriction (Operation 2224). The virtual machine determines whether to inline the value for the field based on the type restriction. If the type restriction restricts the value to conform to a primitive type, then the virtual machine may determine to line the value.

(305) Where the access instruction is to get a field value, one or more embodiments include inlining the value onto an operand stack (Operation 2226). The virtual machine inlines the value for the field onto the operand stack, rather than a reference to the value for the field. The virtual machine then processes the inlined value from the operand stack. Alternatively, where the access instruction is to put a field value, one or more embodiments include popping an inlined value from the operand stack (operation not illustrated). The virtual machine pops the inlined value for the field from the operand stack, rather than a reference to the value for the field. The virtual machine then stores the inlined value into the memory space for the object within the heap.

(306) Where the access instruction is to get a field value, one or more embodiments include pushing a reference to the value onto the operand stack (Operation 22). The virtual machine pushes a reference to the value for the field onto the operand stack. The virtual machine then accesses the value for the field based on the reference. Alternatively, where the access instruction is to put a field value, one or more embodiments include popping a reference to the value from the operand stack (operation not illustrated). The virtual machine pops a reference to the value for the field from the operand stack. The virtual machine then stores the referenced value into the memory space for the object within the heap.

## 7. EXAMPLE EMBODIMENTS

(307) 7.1. Executing a Parametric Method Dependent on an Anchor Constant

(308) A first embodiment includes: while within a first stack frame, on a call stack, corresponding to a first execution of a first caller method: identifying a first invocation instruction to invoke a callee method within a first context; wherein a first type restriction is applied on one or more of a method parameter and a method return value of the callee method within the first context, and the first type restriction prohibits a first value for one or more of the method parameter and the method return value. Responsive to identifying the first invocation instruction: pushing a second stack frame, onto the call stack, corresponding to a second execution of the callee method responsive to the first invocation instruction; passing information representing the first context from the first stack frame to the second stack frame; while within the second stack frame, on the call stack, corresponding to the second execution of the callee method: processing one or more of the method parameter and the method return value based on the first type restriction that is applied within the first context; while within a third stack frame, on the call stack, corresponding to a third execution of a second caller method: identifying a second invocation instruction to invoke the callee method within a second context; wherein a second type restriction is applied on one or more of the method parameter and the method return value within the second context, the second type restriction prohibits a second value for one or more of the method parameter and the method return value, and the first type restriction and the second type restriction are different; responsive to identifying the second invocation instruction: pushing a fourth stack frame, onto the call stack, corresponding to a fourth execution of the callee method responsive to the second invocation instruction; passing information representing the second context from the third stack frame to the fourth stack frame; while within the fourth stack frame, on the call stack, corresponding to the fourth execution of the

callee method: processing one or more of the method parameter and the method return value based on the second type restriction that is applied within the second context.

(309) A second embodiment includes: identifying a plurality of runtime constant pools that are (a) associated with a type and (b) respectively correspond to a plurality of contexts, wherein one or more of the type and a supertype of the type defines a callee method; while within a first stack frame, on a call stack, corresponding to a first execution of a first caller method: identifying a first invocation instruction to invoke the callee method within a first context of the plurality of contexts; responsive to the first invocation instruction: pushing a second stack frame, onto the call stack, corresponding to a second execution of the callee method responsive to the first invocation instruction; determining that a first runtime constant pool, of the plurality of runtime constant pools, corresponds to the first context of the plurality of contexts; storing, into the second stack frame, a first constant pool reference that indicates the first runtime constant pool.

#### 7.2. Creating an Instance of a Parametric Class Dependent on an Anchor Constant

(310) A third embodiment includes: identifying a first creation instruction to create a first object based on a first unspecialized type within a first context, wherein the first object would be of a first specialized type that is the first unspecialized type specialized within the first context; creating the first object, wherein creating the first object comprises: allocating a first memory space to the first object based on one or more of a first memory size and a first memory layout associated with the first specialized type; wherein the first unspecialized type is associated with one or more of a second memory size, different than the first memory size, and a first memory layout, different than the second memory layout; initializing the first object, wherein initializing the first object comprises: executing a constructor defined by one or more of the first unspecialized type and a supertype of the first unspecialized type.

#### 7.3. Accessing a Parametric Field Dependent on an Anchor Constant

(311) A fourth embodiment includes: identifying a first access instruction to access a first field of a first object within a first context, wherein the first object is expected to be of a first specialized type, and the first specialized type is a first unspecialized type specialized within the first context; identifying a second specialized type stored in association with the first object; determining whether the first specialized type matches the second specialized type; responsive to determining that the first specialized type matches the second specialized type: identifying a first memory layout associated with one or more of the first specialized type and the second specialized type; wherein an unspecialized memory layout is associated with the first unspecialized type, and the first memory layout and the unspecialized memory layout are different; accessing the first field of the first object based on the first memory layout.

(312) A fifth embodiment includes: identifying a first access instruction of a first instruction type to access a first field of a first object within a first context; wherein the first context is associated with a first type restriction on the first field that prohibits a first value for the first field; executing the first access instruction to access the first field of the first object; identifying a second access instruction of a second instruction type to access the first field of a second object within a second context; wherein the second context is associated with a second type restriction on the first field that does not prohibit the first value for the first field; wherein the first instruction type and the second instruction type are different; executing the second access instruction to access the first field of the second object.

### 8. MISCELLANEOUS; EXTENSIONS

(313) Embodiments are directed to a system with one or more devices that include a hardware processor and that are configured to perform any of the operations described herein and/or recited in any of the claims below.

(314) In an embodiment, a non-transitory computer readable storage medium comprises instructions which, when executed by one or more hardware processors, causes performance of any of the operations described herein and/or recited in any of the claims.

(315) Any combination of the features and functionalities described herein may be used in accordance with one or more embodiments. In the foregoing specification, embodiments have been described with reference to numerous specific details that may vary from implementation to implementation. The specification and drawings are, accordingly, to be regarded in an illustrative rather than a restrictive sense. The sole and exclusive indicator of the scope of the invention, and what is intended by the applicants to be the scope of the invention, is the literal and equivalent scope of the set of claims that issue from this application, in the specific form in which such claims issue, including any subsequent correction.

## 9. HARDWARE OVERVIEW

(316) According to one embodiment, the techniques described herein are implemented by one or more special-purpose computing devices. The special-purpose computing devices may be hard-wired to perform the techniques, or may include digital electronic devices such as one or more application-specific integrated circuits (ASICs) or field programmable gate arrays (FPGAs) that are persistently programmed to perform the techniques, or may include one or more general purpose hardware processors programmed to perform the techniques pursuant to program instructions in firmware, memory, other storage, or a combination. Such special-purpose computing devices may also combine custom hard-wired logic, ASICs, or FPGAs with custom programming to accomplish the techniques. The special-purpose computing devices may be desktop computer systems, portable computer systems, handheld devices, networking devices or any other device that incorporates hard-wired and/or program logic to implement the techniques.

(317) For example, FIG. 23 is a block diagram that illustrates a computer system **2300** upon which an embodiment of the invention may be implemented. Computer system **2300** includes a bus **2302** or other communication mechanism for communicating information, and a hardware processor **2304** coupled with bus **2302** for processing information. Hardware processor **2304** may be, for example, a general purpose microprocessor.

(318) Computer system **2300** also includes a main memory **2306**, such as a random access memory (RAM) or other dynamic storage device, coupled to bus **2302** for storing information and instructions to be executed by processor **2304**. Main memory **2306** also may be used for storing temporary variables or other intermediate information during execution of instructions to be executed by processor **2304**. Such instructions, when stored in non-transitory storage media accessible to processor **2304**, render computer system **2300** into a special-purpose machine that is customized to perform the operations specified in the instructions.

(319) Computer system **2300** further includes a read only memory (ROM) **2308** or other static storage device coupled to bus **2302** for storing static information and instructions for processor **2304**. A storage device **2310**, such as a magnetic disk or optical disk, is provided and coupled to bus **2302** for storing information and instructions.

(320) Computer system **2300** may be coupled via bus **2302** to a display **2312**, such as a cathode ray tube (CRT), for displaying information to a computer user. An input device **2314**, including alphanumeric and other keys, is coupled to bus **2302** for communicating information and command selections to processor **2304**. Another type of user input device is cursor control **2316**, such as a mouse, a trackball, or cursor direction keys for communicating direction information and command selections to processor **2304** and for controlling cursor movement on display **2312**. This input device typically has two degrees of freedom in two axes, a first axis (e.g., x) and a second axis (e.g., y), that allows the device to specify positions in a plane.

(321) Computer system **2300** may implement the techniques described herein using customized hard-wired logic, one or more ASICs or FPGAs, firmware and/or program logic which in combination with the computer system causes or programs computer system **2300** to be a special-purpose machine. According to one embodiment, the techniques herein are performed by computer system **2300** in response to processor **2304** executing one or more sequences of one or more instructions contained in main memory **2306**. Such instructions may be read into main memory

**2306** from another storage medium, such as storage device **2310**. Execution of the sequences of instructions contained in main memory **2306** causes processor **2304** to perform the process steps described herein. In alternative embodiments, hard-wired circuitry may be used in place of or in combination with software instructions.

(322) The term “storage media” as used herein refers to any non-transitory media that store data and/or instructions that cause a machine to operate in a specific fashion. Such storage media may comprise non-volatile media and/or volatile media. Non-volatile media includes, for example, optical or magnetic disks, such as storage device **2310**. Volatile media includes dynamic memory, such as main memory **2306**. Common forms of storage media include, for example, a floppy disk, a flexible disk, hard disk, solid state drive, magnetic tape, or any other magnetic data storage medium, a CD-ROM, any other optical data storage medium, any physical medium with patterns of holes, a RAM, a PROM, and EPROM, a FLASH-EPROM, NVRAM, any other memory chip or cartridge.

(323) Storage media is distinct from but may be used in conjunction with transmission media. Transmission media participates in transferring information between storage media. For example, transmission media includes coaxial cables, copper wire and fiber optics, including the wires that comprise bus **2302**. Transmission media can also take the form of acoustic or light waves, such as those generated during radio-wave and infra-red data communications.

(324) Various forms of media may be involved in carrying one or more sequences of one or more instructions to processor **2304** for execution. For example, the instructions may initially be carried on a magnetic disk or solid state drive of a remote computer. The remote computer can load the instructions into its dynamic memory and send the instructions over a telephone line using a modem. A modem local to computer system **2300** can receive the data on the telephone line and use an infra-red transmitter to convert the data to an infra-red signal. An infra-red detector can receive the data carried in the infra-red signal and appropriate circuitry can place the data on bus **2302**. Bus **2302** carries the data to main memory **2306**, from which processor **2304** retrieves and executes the instructions. The instructions received by main memory **2306** may optionally be stored on storage device **2310** either before or after execution by processor **2304**.

(325) Computer system **2300** also includes a communication interface **2318** coupled to bus **2302**. Communication interface **2318** provides a two-way data communication coupling to a network link **2320** that is connected to a local network **2322**. For example, communication interface **2318** may be an integrated services digital network (ISDN) card, cable modem, satellite modem, or a modem to provide a data communication connection to a corresponding type of telephone line. As another example, communication interface **2318** may be a local area network (LAN) card to provide a data communication connection to a compatible LAN. Wireless links may also be implemented. In any such implementation, communication interface **2318** sends and receives electrical, electromagnetic or optical signals that carry digital data streams representing various types of information.

(326) Network link **2320** typically provides data communication through one or more networks to other data devices. For example, network link **2320** may provide a connection through local network **2322** to a host computer **2324** or to data equipment operated by an Internet Service Provider (ISP) **2326**. ISP **2326** in turn provides data communication services through the world wide packet data communication network now commonly referred to as the “Internet” **2328**. Local network **2322** and Internet **2328** both use electrical, electromagnetic or optical signals that carry digital data streams. The signals through the various networks and the signals on network link **2320** and through communication interface **2318**, which carry the digital data to and from computer system **2300**, are example forms of transmission media.

(327) Computer system **2300** can send messages and receive data, including program code, through the network(s), network link **2320** and communication interface **2318**. In the Internet example, a server **2330** might transmit a requested code for an application program through Internet **2328**, ISP **2326**, local network **2322** and communication interface **2318**.

(328) The received code may be executed by processor **2304** as it is received, and/or stored in storage device **2310**, or other non-volatile storage for later execution.

(329) In the foregoing specification, embodiments of the invention have been described with reference to numerous specific details that may vary from implementation to implementation. The specification and drawings are, accordingly, to be regarded in an illustrative rather than a restrictive sense. The sole and exclusive indicator of the scope of the invention, and what is intended by the applicants to be the scope of the invention, is the literal and equivalent scope of the set of claims that issue from this application, in the specific form in which such claims issue, including any subsequent correction.

## Claims

1. One or more non-transitory computer readable media storing instructions which, when executed by one or more hardware processors, cause: identifying a first call to a first application programming interface (API) point; determining that the first call to the first API point is made in association with a first selector value; determining that the first API point depends on a parametric constant; and executing a bootstrap method corresponding to the parametric constant, wherein executing the bootstrap method comprises: determining whether the first selector value is valid with respect to the parametric constant; responsive to determining that the first selector value is valid with respect to the parametric constant; returning a first anchor value based on the first selector value; and storing the first anchor value as a first resolved value for a first resolution state of the parametric constant.
2. The media of claim 1, further storing instructions which cause: determining whether the first selector value matches any resolved value for any resolution state of the parametric constant; and wherein executing the bootstrap method is responsive to determining that the first selector value does not match any resolved value for any resolution state of the parametric constant.
3. The media of claim 1, further storing instructions which cause: determining that an operand associated with the first call to the first API point comprises a particular constant, wherein the first call is made from a caller type; and storing, as a second resolved value for a second resolution state of the particular constant, (a) information indicating the first API point and (b) information indicating the first anchor value.
4. The media of claim 1, wherein: the first API point is a type; the first anchor value indicates one or more of: a first memory layout associated with a specialized type that is the type specialized based on the first anchor value; a first memory size associated with the specialized type; and an object that represents the specialized type.
5. The media of claim 1, wherein: the first API point is a field; one or more of a type and a supertype of the type defines the field; one or more of the type and the supertype of the type specifies that an unspecialized type is associated with the field; and the field is of a specialized type that is the unspecialized type specialized based on the first anchor value.
6. The media of claim 5, wherein: the first anchor value indicates a type restriction on the field; and the type restriction prohibits a value, which is valid for the unspecialized type, for the field.
7. The media of claim 1, wherein: the first API point is a method; one or more of a type and a supertype of the type defines the method; one or more of the type and the supertype of the type specifies that an unspecialized type is associated with one or more of a method parameter and a method return value of the method; and one or more of the method parameter and the method return value is of a specialized type that is the unspecialized type specialized based on the first anchor value.
8. The media of claim 7, wherein: the first anchor value indicates a type restriction on one or more of the method parameter and the method return value; and the type restriction prohibits a value, which is valid for the unspecialized type, for one or more of the method parameter and the method

return value.

9. The media of claim 1, wherein the first anchor value indicates the first selector value.

10. The media of claim 1, wherein: the first anchor value indicates a default anchor value for the parametric constant; the default anchor value is determined during preparation of a type defining the parametric constant; and the first anchor value is determined (a) subsequent to the preparation of the type defining the parametric constant and (b) responsive to the first call to the first API point.

11. The media of claim 1, further storing instructions which cause: executing the first API point, responsive to the first call to the first API point, based on the first anchor value.

12. The media of claim 1, wherein determining that the first API point depends on the parametric constant comprises: determining that the first API point is associated with a parametric attribute comprising a parametric constant reference; and determining that the parametric constant reference indicates the parametric constant.

13. The media of claim 1, wherein: the first call to the first API point comprises an instruction and an operand; the operand is a linkage constant that is in an unresolved state; and an information structure for the linkage constant indicates the first API point and the first selector value.

14. The media of claim 13, further storing instructions comprising: resolving a symbolic reference to the first API point prior to resolving the linkage constant.

15. The media of claim 13, further storing instructions which cause: storing a second resolved value for a second resolution state of the linkage constant that indicates the first anchor value.

16. The media of claim 1, further storing instructions which cause: identifying a second call to the first API point, wherein the second call to the first API point is made in association with a second selector value different than the first selector value; and executing the bootstrap method associated with the parametric constant, wherein executing the bootstrap method comprises: determining whether the second selector value is valid with respect to the parametric constant; responsive to determining that the second selector value is valid with respect to the parametric constant; returning a second anchor value based on the second selector value; storing the second anchor value as a second resolved value for a second resolution state of the parametric constant; wherein the first selector value and the second selector value are different; and wherein the first anchor value and the second anchor value are different.

17. The media of claim 1, further storing instructions which cause: identifying a second call to the first API point, wherein the second call to the first API point is made in association with a second selector value different than the first selector value; determining that the first resolution state of the parametric constant, of a plurality of resolution states of the parametric constant, is further associated with the second selector value; and executing the first API point, responsive to the second call to the first API point, based on the first anchor value that is the first resolved value for the first resolution state of the parametric constant.

18. The media of claim 1, further storing instructions which cause: identifying a second call to a second API point, wherein the second call to the second API point is made in association with the first selector value; determining that the second API point depends on the parametric constant; determining that the first resolution state of the parametric constant is associated with the first selector value; and executing the second API point, responsive to the second call to the second API point, based on the first anchor value that is the first resolved value for the first resolution state of the parametric constant.

19. The media of claim 1, wherein the first anchor value is not accessible by a callee type making the first call to the first API point.

20. The media of claim 1, wherein: the first API point is a class; the first anchor value indicates an object representing a specialized class that is the class specialized based on the first anchor value; and the object is accessible by a callee type making the first call to the first API point.

21. The media of claim 1, wherein: the first call to the first API point is associated with an operand; and the operand is a linkage constant; no loadable value is associated with the linkage constant.

22. The media of claim 1, wherein: the first API point is a class; the first call to the first API point is associated with an operand; the operand is a linkage constant; a loadable value for the linkage constant indicates an object representing a specialized class that is the class specialized based on the first anchor value; and the loadable value for the linkage constant is accessible by a callee type making the first call to the first API point.

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